

HOW TO GET INTO AMERICA'S ELITE COLLEGES

THE ULTIMATE GUIDE



PROVEN STRATEGIES USED FOR ACCEPTANCE INTO
STANFORD, PRINCETON, CALTECH, & OTHER HIGHLY
SELECTIVE UNIVERSITIES AT INCREDIBLE RATES



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Introduction

The College Admissions Dilemma

As the parent of a college applicant, you're probably stressed out like no other.

When you applied to college, you likely submitted an SAT score, your transcript, and perhaps an essay.

Today's college admissions landscape looks much different. Unfortunately, with so many highly qualified applicants applying to college each year, many top schools have acceptance rates in the single digits, a discouraging trend we observe every year!

Nevertheless, despite feeling like every other college applicant has achieved a high GPA, ACT or SAT score and participated in meaningful extracurricular activities, there are still ways for your child to stand out and get admissions committees' attention.

At this point, all you want are some good answers to a few burning questions about the application process, the answers to which fall into one of two categories: 1) things you can't change, and 2) things you can affect.

Things You Can't Change

Example questions that fall into this category include:

- Are my child's grades up to this point high enough?
- My child is not class president. Are they doomed?
- My child has not faced a significant hardship. Will this negatively affect their personal statement?
- Does being part of a non-minority group make my child a less competitive candidate?

Things You Can Affect

Example questions that fall into this category include:

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- How many AP courses should my child take?
- What SAT score does my child need?
- Is my child selecting the right extracurricular activities?
- Where should my child apply?
- What should my child write their personal statement and other college essays about?
- How can my child avoid making their essays sound cliché?
- Whom should my child ask for recommendation letters?
- How can my child ace their interviews?

Since I'm in the business of helping applicants improve their odds of getting in and reducing stress, I want to focus only on things your child can affect at this point.

In this guide, you'll learn how your child can:

- Decide the number of AP courses to take.
- Determine the correct SAT or ACT score to target.
- Develop a unique extracurricular profile.
- Apply to the right schools to maximize admissions odds.
- Identify the ideal recommendation letter writers and ask for great letters.
- Write a unique personal statement to stand out.
- Decide which experiences to highlight in the Common App Activities section.
- Write strong supplemental application essays.
- Ace their interviews.

Let's get right into it.

Lesson 1

The GPA and Test Scores Your Child Needs to Compete

There's no way around it: your child's grades and standardized test scores (i.e., their stats) collectively represent the most important factor in college admissions. The higher their stats, the higher their admissions odds.

Although the bulk of this guide focuses on strategies *outside* of achieving high grades and standardized test scores, we'll briefly cover two common questions regarding course selection and the SAT/ACT.

How many AP courses and tests should my child take per year?

Your child should consider the following factors when deciding:

How many they could take without hurting their grades: While it's better to receive a B in an AP or Honors class vs. an A in a regular class, your child should be thoughtful about how many AP courses they could take before significantly compromising their GPA. Relatedly, they'll want to make sure to give themselves enough time to study hard for each class so they can do well on the AP exam.

How many they could take without compromising the depth of their extracurricular activities: Most applicants to highly selective colleges have strong grades and standardized test scores. Therefore, the true differentiator between standout applicants and those who are simply academically high-achieving is the strength of their extracurricular profile. Because AP courses tend to require a lot of study time, your child will have to be thoughtful about the number they take on before compromising the meaningfulness of their extracurricular activities.

What their school allows: Some schools put a cap on the number of AP classes students can take each year. Depending on how many that is, they may choose to take all or some of the offered AP courses and tests.

Which colleges they're targeting: The more selective the school, the more they'll expect that your child take the toughest courses available. At Ivy League and other elite universities (e.g., Stanford), we recommend aiming for 7 to 12 AP courses total.

How many their peers take each year: Because context matters so much in college admissions, your child will be judged against their peers with regard not only to AP test scores, but also number of AP courses and tests taken.

What SAT or ACT score does my child need to get into their dream school?

Your child should aim for a score that is at minimum between the 25th and 75th percentiles of admitted applicants at a given school. All Ivy League and other top colleges publish these statistics online. Students whose scores fall below the 25th percentile should concentrate their efforts on improving their scores to make their applications more competitive.

Many students who *do* have an SAT or ACT score that falls within the 25th and 75th percentile range of admitted applicants at their dream school believe they should invest a lot more time into studying, but the truth is, most will only see negligible improvements in their test scores—and college admission odds.

Even students with perfect standardized test scores get rejected because they've neglected other important parts of their college applications. For this reason, we advise students to spend significant time developing a unique extracurricular profile, which most differentiates the star applicants from those who are academically high-achieving, yet average outside of the classroom setting.

For example, a student with an SAT or ACT score in the 70th percentile who has spent her entire high school career establishing herself as a fashion blogger could spend the next several months studying to attain a test score closer to the 75th or even 80th percentile of admitted applicants at her dream school, *or* she could organize a charity

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event to help female high school students from low-income backgrounds obtain dresses for prom. By choosing the latter option, this student will demonstrate her commitment to her specialty—fashion—as well as her ability to make a deep community impact—both of which are more impressive to college admissions committees than a slight score increase on the SAT or ACT.

Lesson 2

How to Develop a Unique Extracurricular Profile

Proven approaches and examples of extracurricular activities to help your child stand out on college applications

Top colleges receive an increasing number of applications each year from incredibly accomplished students for roughly the same number of spots.

At schools like Stanford and Harvard, acceptance rates have plummeted to around 5% overall in recent years. Rates are even lower among regular decision applications vs. early action or early decision applicants. This trend isn't limited to private institutions. Elite public universities, like UCLA, University of Michigan, and University of Virginia, are also seeing significant drops in admissions rates.

Why Being “Well Rounded” No Longer Works Well

Parents and students often believe that the best way to succeed in an increasingly competitive college application process is to enroll in all their school's toughest courses and receive straight A's, top-notch ACT or SAT scores, and participate in as many extracurricular activities as possible so that they are seen as “well rounded.”

Teachers and guidance counselors often propagate this idea by telling students that elite colleges will not accept them if they receive B's, attain less-than-stellar test scores, or do not participate in every extracurricular activity offered by their school and prestigious summer programs.

To be clear, your child's grades and standardized test scores (i.e., their stats) collectively represent the most important factor in college admissions. (Note: this

doesn't mean they should enroll in every tough course at their high school and local community colleges. More on this point later.)

However, these days, most applicants to elite universities are highly accomplished. In addition to having excellent stats, many applicants have engaged in an abundance of extracurricular activities: they've served in a variety of leadership positions; volunteered with important organizations; taken summer courses at universities over the summer; traveled abroad for a mission trip; and participated in musical, theater, and athletic groups.

The problem is that when so many excellent candidates apply with similar applications, it becomes difficult for admissions committees to differentiate students from one another. It's not surprising, then, that so many of these qualified applicants are rejected each year.

The approach of participating in tons of extracurricular activities to appear well rounded used to work. However, the college admissions game has changed from the time you or your child's counselor applied to universities. If you stick to the old approach, your child's admissions become a roll of the dice.

(Note: Parents and students who take the old approach to college admissions also experience personal drawbacks like stress, fatigue, and the feeling of never having enough time to pursue things they find most meaningful. When you drive your child across town to participate in various activities, constantly perform chores like washing soccer jerseys, and fill your weekends trying to perfect mock trial rebuttals, you risk sacrificing what matters most to you.)

What Are Colleges Looking For?

When admissions readers encounter a student with a common list of "well-rounded" extracurricular activities, it's difficult to pinpoint what makes them different from their peers. For instance, if asked what makes Dan—a student who did well in all his classes and on standardized tests, joined 6 clubs on campus, and played trombone in the school band—memorable, you'd struggle to come up with a good answer.

On the other hand, Susan played trombone in the school band, raised money to purchase band equipment for children in local, underfunded elementary schools, and organized a band competition in her community for charity that was covered by multiple media outlets, including the Chicago Sun Times. Susan would easily be remembered as “the charitable musician.” She has an “it factor” that she could leverage for successful admissions.

When evaluating applicants’ extracurricular profiles, **colleges are looking for students who are specialists in what they do and genuinely interesting people.**

Specialists

College admissions reps routinely discuss how they’re looking to admit diverse applicants. Most people misunderstand this to mean that colleges simply want to accept individuals from diverse backgrounds with respect to ethnicity, religion, socioeconomic status, and so on. While these personal factors are important, colleges are also looking for diversity when it comes to students’ abilities, interests, and achievements.

The more competitive the college, the more they’re looking to admit highly accomplished specialists in various arenas. In other words, they would much rather admit three students whose achievements are at the 99th percentile of science, community service, *or* teaching than three students who are at the 80th percentile in science, music, *and* community service.

Being a specialist literally and figuratively pays in American society. One prominent example comes from the world of physicians, where specialists (e.g., orthopedic surgeons) far out-earn generalists (e.g., family medicine physicians).

Interesting People

In addition to becoming a specialist, your child should aim to pursue interesting activities that will lead to them being seen as an interesting person.

Admissions readers can easily figure out how a student like well-rounded Dan got involved in his various extracurricular activities. Moreover, they would assume that he followed the paths of other students before him.

In comparison, specialist Susan's achievements would be much more difficult to explain. How did she raise so much money to purchase expensive instruments? How did she organize such a large competition? How did she gain the attention of major media outlets?

If we knew nothing else about Dan or Susan, we would likely find Susan to be the more interesting student, as well as the student who has demonstrated greater initiative, impact, and leadership.

To truly stand out, your child's extracurricular accomplishments should be difficult to explain. That is, someone should hear about their accomplishments and wonder, "How on Earth did a high school student do *that*?"

Benefits of Extracurricular Activities

Although this guide is written from a college admissions perspective, we recommend that your child pursue extracurricular activities that interest them for several other reasons, including: gaining deeper knowledge of academic subjects; refining non-academic skills; exploring curiosities; gaining clarity around potential career options; participating in team activities; honing leadership, initiative, and other valuable personal qualities; personal fulfillment; and fun.

Common Objections to Developing a Specialized Extracurricular Profile

At this point, you're probably questioning whether and how your child will ever demonstrate achievement at the highest levels in a given area, how they will find the time, and so on. You may attribute incredible achievements—publishing a book, starting

an activist movement, publishing original scientific research in a noteworthy journal—to genius, rather than something attainable for your child.

Before we dive into our step-by-step approach to developing a standout extracurricular profile, it's important that I address your objections, hesitations, and questions. Otherwise, you're unlikely to ever buy in and will instead probably revert to the well-rounded approach.

There's more to life than attending Yale or some other elite school. Why not just let kids be kids rather than fuel their college admissions stress?

I agree that there's more to life than attending an Ivy League or other prestigious school.

However, I believe that there's tremendous value in doing so, such as the opportunity to take courses with world-renowned faculty, build a network of bright, creative, and interesting fellow students, access incredible resources, and have a brand name on your resume that can open all sorts of personal and professional doors. As the son of immigrant parents and a Cornell and UCLA alum, I can personally attest to all these benefits.

My goal for this article is not to communicate that your child must attend a well-known university, or that failure to do so will lead to fewer life opportunities.

Instead, I'm offering my insights—to interested families—on getting into prestigious schools, based on my 15 years of college admissions advising experience.

Here's the most interesting part: **students who pursue a focused extracurricular path instead of trying to join every activity and mimic what their peers are doing end up spending less time overall on extracurriculars; experience less stress by not trying to “keep up”; and stand out on college applications.**

If your child is going to devote significant time to pursuits outside the classroom, why not go about it the right way?

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I'm skeptical that my child can get significant media attention/lead a significant nonprofit organization/etc. How can my “normal” child, a non-genius, ever achieve things at *that* level?

Parents often view a successful student's peak achievement and think, “My child is bright, but he's not one of *those* students” before either: a) essentially giving up on their child's chances of getting into a top college or b) trying to keep up with the Joneses' kids by encouraging them to join every activity and falling into the trap that is the extracurricular activity rat race.

What these parents don't realize, however, is that the successful student's peak achievement reflects years of effort and incremental achievement in a singular area. These small steps are quite achievable and don't require any sort of genius to take. (Note: I will provide examples later in the article.)

Imagine you're about to go on a 3-mile hike to the top of a 2,000-foot mountain and back. If asked how you would make it to the top, you would probably tell me how you're going to follow the marked trail, one step at a time, to eventually get there. On the other hand, you wouldn't give up before you started thinking it would require one big leap to get to the top.

I encourage you to approach your child's extracurricular activities like the deliberate hiker rather than the irrational person who questions their leaping ability. If your child takes one small step after the other, they'll eventually develop a standout extracurricular profile. The key is to focus on a single trail, rather than routinely veering off-course.

How important will grades and test scores be if my child is able to stand out as an interesting specialist?

To reiterate: nothing can substitute for your child's grades and standardized test scores, which make up the foundation of your child's college applications.

Your child must enroll in challenging courses and do well in them if they aspire to attend top schools. Easy course loads, as well as low grades or test scores, cannot be overcome by developing a standout extracurricular profile.

However, it's equally important to emphasize that doing well in challenging courses and on standardized tests like the SAT or AP Exams is not enough to get into elite universities. To stand out from the competition, your child must pursue interesting activities in a focused way to demonstrate expertise, initiative, leadership, impact, and other positive qualities.

If you don't believe me, you can find countless examples online of high-achieving students (e.g., 3.9 unweighted GPA, 1550 SAT score) who don't get into any of their top choices. On the other hand, we work with several students each year with impressive, but not mind-bending stats who outperform star peers at their school when it comes to college admissions. The difference comes down to their extracurricular profile and how they communicate their background and goals through their college essays.

Your child's academic goal should be to achieve grades and test scores that fall at or above the 25th percentile of accepted students (the higher, the better) to have a realistic chance of getting in. Beyond that, it's all about extracurriculars, essays, and letters of recommendation for college.

Is it ever too late to follow the specialist approach described in this article?

The short answer is no, but I'll return to the hiking example to elaborate on this one.

Suppose you had 4 hours to hike to the top of the mountain and back. This would be doable if you're reasonably fit. On the other hand, if you had 1 hour to make the trip, you would only get so far before time ran out. That said, you would still get some exercise in the latter situation.

In the same way, your child will likely achieve greater heights with their extracurriculars if they begin their focused journey sooner rather than later. However, if your child starts

later, say, midway through their junior year, they can still make significant progress with their activities. If your child gets creative, they may be able to accelerate the process.

My point is that your child should begin developing a focused, standout extracurricular profile the moment they learn about this approach, whether a freshman or rising senior.

How *Not* to Pursue Extracurricular Activities

Responding to common objections is the first step to shedding longstanding misconceptions about extracurricular activities for college admissions.

Before we explore effective extracurricular strategies, I'll highlight misguided approaches that will lead to your child blending in with the rest of the applicant pool. Don't worry if you or your child have been guilty of anything on this list. Becoming aware and changing course now will help your child get ahead.

Mistake 1: Asking “What extracurricular activities should my child pursue?” or “What’s the best route to take?”

Every year, tens, if not hundreds, of parents ask me what the best strategy is when it comes to extracurriculars. When I probe further, it becomes clear they're not asking me whether their child should look to be “well rounded” versus a specialist. Instead, they're essentially asking me, “What is THE path my child should take?” during the school year, summer, etc.

The best route for your child will look very different from other students', even from those who got into top schools. In other words, there is no single path to achieving extracurricular success.

Suppose we were evaluating summer activities for your child. A prestigious math program at MIT would be great for your child if they're elite in that area and looking to further develop their skills, win competitions, conduct math research, and so on.

On the other hand, the same program would be a poor fit for your child if they were looking to scale their nonprofit business focused on teaching computer coding to

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individuals in their community without a strong educational background. In the latter case, your child would want to devote their time and energy to those efforts and would be wise to recognize the opportunity cost of attending the summer program.

Any time your child asks, in a general sense, “What extracurricular activities should I do?”, treat that as a sign of lacking clarity. It’s much better to take things slower than you’re comfortable with to identify the right opportunities for your child than to jump into things out of anxiety or because you heard an activity “looks good” on college applications.

Mistake 2: Becoming a chronic joiner

Many high-achieving high school students are what I call “chronic joiners.” These students tend to be ambitious, looking for opportunities to impress others.

A chronic joiner, for example, holds a non-officer membership on the yearbook staff, serves as secretary of the French club, volunteers 20 hours at the local soup kitchen, participates in the math club, and perhaps sings in choir. This student probably is enrolled in the maximum number of AP courses possible, too.

By participating in too many extracurricular activities, a chronic joiner spends so much time doing busy work for various committees, sitting in meetings, and attending mandatory rehearsals that having time to see friends, complete homework, and pursue independent projects becomes almost impossible.

Moreover, a chronic joiner demonstrates little initiative, creativity, ambition, and perseverance to admissions committees. In fact, this student would be viewed as interchangeable with another student, because nearly any student can fill these positions. So why blend in by filling these positions at all?

College admissions committees view the chronic joiner as someone who has developed few, if any, discernibly unique skills, as well as an applicant who has not experienced many challenges to join certain organizations or achieve in standout ways. They simply followed a prescribed path. Real talent and skills need to be developed individually and

over a long period of time. To make matters worse, many of these positions require busy work that do not benefit the student.

The chronic joiner is likely following in the footsteps of his friends, older siblings, cousins, and others. Indeed, they may be following the paths of older siblings and cousins who were once successful in the admissions process.

After all, if a student's sister was accepted to a well-known school and participated in the same activities and took the same courses, why wouldn't the younger sibling be accepted, too? We've already covered how college admissions has become competitive to the point that students need to be unique to be successful, not well rounded.

Looking around to see what others are doing is a surefire way to blend in—and not stand out.

What your child should do instead

Nowadays, admissions readers want your child to be somewhat rough around the edges. They want to accept your child only if they demonstrate ambition and curiosity and tackle a problem or an interest directly. Your child should demonstrate openness to change and willingness to take risks, pursue activities that they love, even if the paths they follow are messy, complex, and extremely difficult to do well in. They want your child to demonstrate a willingness to make mistakes that are intelligent and interesting. Moreover, they want your child to understand that failure and well-informed mistakes are necessary on the road to innovation and change.

Mistake 3: Focusing on the end goal or a year-by-year extracurricular roadmap

It's common for families to ask me years in advance what extracurricular activities their child should pursue during each year of high school, as well as what "capstone project" (more on this later, but it's essentially a student's greatest extracurricular achievement) they should complete.

I don't know. Neither does your child. And that's precisely the way it should be.

The earlier your child is in their high school career, the more they should focus on exploring things they might be interested in. As time goes on and your child develops more clarity around their interests, they should go deeper with the things they enjoy and cut out the rest. Think of this approach as an extracurricular funnel.

When students and parents ask me during freshman or sophomore year about their year-by-year extracurricular roadmap or what they should focus on during the summer before their senior year, it's impossible for me to answer well because a lot can change between their question and final summer. What if we select an end goal that the student no longer wants to pursue in six months?

What your child should do instead

The better approach is for your child to start out doing a few things they think they'll enjoy. Likely, your child will be interested in some of their choices and uninterested in others. They should identify two or three next steps for the activity areas they're interested in and pursue those, letting go of the one(s) they don't like and going deeper with the ones they do like.

It would be wrong to equate not having a roadmap with not being systematic. Your child should systematically explore interests without having a senior year destination. It's likely your child will achieve bigger things at that time than they could have initially envisioned.

In the tech startup world, there is a philosophy known as "fail fast." Instead of trying to build something huge at the start without first validating the idea's merit, people who fail fast extensively test options and make incremental developments to determine whether an idea has value. They cut losses—that is, the things that aren't working—quickly and turn their attention to the next idea that could work.

Eventually, your child will develop outstanding skills in their areas of interests, their end goals will become clear, and they'll achieve at higher levels than their peers.

Mistake 4: Waiting and hoping your child will follow their "passion"

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I'm not sure when "follow your passion" became such a buzz phrase. What I do know is that buying into the idea has been problematic for many families.

Some people approach choosing a passion or calling as if they were buying something from a catalog. Others believe that students should wait until, one day, they realize what they truly love and only then will they be able to fully apply themselves.

(Note: There is a minority of people who have always known what they want to pursue. However, while these individuals tend to know what area they want to focus on, they still need to figure out the specifics. For instance, someone who has a passion for photography may not know what type of photography they want to pursue, or whether to become a professional photographer themselves vs. a photography critic.)

My experience has shown me that the idea of waiting to realize or choosing a passion and *then* going all in is completely backwards.

Typically, the most successful students are those who do something for a while that interests them, even if they're not initially good at it. As they become more skilled, they develop a passion for it, and pursue the activity at increasingly higher levels.

I'll offer an example from my professional career to demonstrate the point. Even though I've been helping students get into top colleges since 2004, I only started writing about college admissions in 2014. Back then, I wasn't very good at it. However, I kept writing because I wanted to provide valuable guidance for students, parents, and guidance counselors everywhere. Eventually, I became skilled at writing and developed a passion for it. As I write this guide, my insights have been featured on [The Washington Post](#), [US News & World Report](#), [New York Post](#), and many other prominent websites. If I had waited to follow my passion for writing, I probably wouldn't be reaching thousands of families with this information.

What your child should do instead

Finding a passion should be an active, deliberate process. Rather than wait around, join everything, or join what they think they should, your child should make small, educated bets on what they might like and go from there.

If your child goes deeper in areas of interest, over time they will become the student that admissions readers evaluate and think, “Oh, that’s the student who studied rare species of plants in Colorado,” “That is the guy who wrote a book about video games,” “That’s the young lady whose pancake blog went viral,” or “That student filmed a documentary about homeless dogs in New York.”

On the other hand, no admissions counselors will remember that your child was part of the Spanish club or that they were a supporting actress in a few school plays.

Here are some ways your child can explore extracurricular possibilities:

Reading. Your child can read books about a topic that interests them. The goal is not to reread a childhood favorite (e.g., Harry Potter) or read a classic, canonical work of literature (e.g., Moby Dick) that will probably not interest your child, unless they are interested in American novels or whales. Nonfiction books and How-To guides on topics that interest your child can be excellent choices. Podcasts, blogs, websites, and articles from *The Economist*, *The Atlantic*, *The New Yorker*, or another periodical that excites your child can also work.

Individual practice. Students with interests in music, theater, sports, painting, photograph, or writing can use this time to build on previous skills or explore new interests. To improve, your child should spend time practicing on their own, take private lessons, and participate in elective courses that teach new skills.

Informational meetings. Attending a meeting or two of a club can be a useful way to see what time commitment an organization will demand of your child, and if your child is interested at all. It’s ok to attend a meeting or two or volunteer a few times and to decide not to pursue an activity.

Informational interviews. Students with longstanding interests in organizations that do not commonly host high school students can be difficult to find, but that does not mean they are inaccessible. To reach out to leaders in these organizations, your child can set up informal, informational interviews.

Volunteering and unpaid internships. Many students make the mistake of volunteering at an organization like a homeless shelter, soup kitchen, or a retirement

home simply because they believe that it will make them look like a “good person.” If your child is interested in painting, they should consider doing something like teaching art classes to students from low-income backgrounds. Historical societies, museums, animal shelters, art galleries, creative nonprofits, labs at local universities, and other unique organizations are always looking for extra help.

Mistake 5: Spending too much time on uninteresting or unimpressive activities

Many popular activities consume a lot of time and interfere with study schedules.

Take sports, for example. It’s common for a student who plays varsity basketball to wait an hour each day after school before participating in a two-hour practice. It could be 8PM by the time the student gets home, showers, eats, and begins homework.

There is absolutely nothing wrong with sports (I love sports)—or academic decathlon, chess club, debate, and other activities. However, many popular extracurricular activities take up a lot of time and can impact your child’s academic performance, as well as their ability to develop a standout extracurricular profile, pursue hobbies, or spend time with friends and family.

I’m not suggesting that your child leave every time-consuming activity they’re part of. If your child truly enjoys an activity, they should continue with it, recognizing that it won’t help them stand out on college applications. However, I recommend being involved in no more than one such activity. Moreover, I recommend cutting out *any* activity that your child doesn’t love, is hugely popular, and takes up a lot of time.

Mistake 6: Competing in competitive areas

In his book, *How to Be a High School Superstar* (which I highly recommend), Cal Newport documents how, despite slight differences in talent, Luciano Pavarotti is a far more recognizable opera singer than Juan Diego Florez. However, this difference has likely contributed to their large differences in income. While Florez probably earns a good living, Pavarotti’s estate was estimated to be worth \$275-\$475 million dollars.

Newport used this example to coin the term, “The Superstar Effect”: people who are at the top of their field receive disproportionately greater rewards. He then goes on to describe how students would be wise to become superstars in their chosen field.

I have consistently observed how the most successful college applicants were the ones who not only achieved great stats, but also superstar status. They’re remembered by admissions committees as “That young man who did X” or “That young woman who achieved Y.” This point is closely associated with the “Specialist” section above.

What your child should do instead

When faced with the choice of becoming a specialist in more than one area, your child should choose the one in which they’re likely to be the best.

The more crowded the activity, the less likely your child is to be the best or among the best. For instance, because debate is such a popular activity, your child will be competing against thousands of other bright students across the country. If they end up as the best debater in the country, they will stand out on college applications. However, if they’re among the top 5-10% of debaters nationally, top colleges will not be impressed.

Does this mean your child shouldn’t pursue debate? Not necessarily. However, your child should be thoughtful about *how* they pursue debate. If they’re doing it just for fun or to spend time with their friends, they should treat debate as recreation and not devote too much extra time to it.

On the other hand, if your child is skilled at debate but is simply not among America’s best, they can think of ways to be the best at something associated with debate. For example, if your child enjoys making videos, they can start and grow what eventually becomes the most accessed debate tutorial YouTube channel. Or, your child can organize a series of debates in her local community where experts in various fields discuss current events. These debates can be broadcasted live and the series can spread to other cities, college campuses, and so on.

While your entrepreneurial child will not be known to admissions committees as the best high school debater in America, they will solidify their superstar status as “That young woman who founded the debate series that swept Texas.”

(Note: Some students misinterpret this advice and pursue the most obscure uncommon activities in hopes of standing out. Admissions committees can see through this from a mile away. Being a nationally-ranked yodeler, especially if it’s not associated with your other interests or personal background, is not going to impress folks much.)

Mistake 7: Downplaying activities because they’re “just a hobby”

Many parents, students, and guidance counselors mistakenly believe that some activities—or types of activities—are inherently better than others when it comes to impressing admissions committees.

For example, varsity sports, model UN, yearbook, robotics club, and summer programs are assumed to be more impressive than nature photography, coding at home, or blogging.

Most times when I ask parents what their child does extracurricularly, they stop at listing school clubs and community service activities. When I ask how they spend their time on weekends or with friends, parents tell me that their child, for example, paints during nearly every minute of free time, but that it’s “just a hobby.”

My ears perk up anytime a parent or student attempts to downplay the significance of activities that they devote tons of time to but that don’t fall under the made-up category of “serious extracurriculars.”

What your child should do instead

Your child has devoted a lot of time to certain activities and has developed a passion for them. Why not leverage this passion for extracurricular success rather than waiting for some other activity to pique their interest?

The previous debate example was meant to demonstrate that your art-loving child need not be the next Picasso to stand out through art. If they love teaching, why not volunteer

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at a local elementary school's art class? How about preparing art kits for children who are spending weeks at the local children's hospital? Both first steps can serve as the foundation for something much larger and demonstrate your child's initiative.

How to Pursue Extracurricular Activities the Right Way

Earlier, I didn't stop at listing things your child should avoid when pursuing extracurriculars. Instead, we reviewed various common extracurricular missteps, why they're a problem, and what your child should do instead.

This section is intended to build on how your child should ideally pursue extracurriculars. While your child's path will be unique to them, I've distilled success principles based on the hundreds of students I've supported as an advisor.

Strategy 1: Treat time as your greatest asset

Everyone gets 24 hours a day. Yet, few people accomplish much more than others with the same time allotment.

The most accomplished people I know—whether in their personal or professional life—are the ones who protect their time at all costs, devoting it only to the people and activities they enjoy most.

Derek Sivers, an entrepreneur and writer, published a famous, 111-word blog post in 2009, titled, "No 'yes.' Either 'HELL YEAH!' or 'no.'" The idea is that you should say "no" to everything that you feel anything less than, "Wow! That would be amazing!" By doing so, you leave room for the rare things that get you really excited.

It's tough enough for well-intentioned adults to carve out time for priorities. For overcommitted high schoolers surrounded by overcommitted peers, this is especially difficult.

If you're reading this article early in your child's high school career, you can encourage them to wade into different activities. If your child is an upperclassman, they'll have to

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cut out unimportant, unimpressive, uninteresting, and unnecessarily time-consuming activities.

I advise my students to schedule free time in their calendars to allow for meaningful exploration. For instance, your child can block out 5-7PM three evenings a week to try something they've been meaning to but haven't yet gotten around to. In other words, the blocked-out time is meant to be used purposefully, not to watch a TV sitcom while eating potato chips. (unless they're conducting research for their upcoming sitcom pilot, of course.)

The biggest obstacle to freeing up time tends to be parent and student anxiety. Students often try this approach for a week or two, before they feel internal or parental pressure to do something more tangible—join a club, enroll in a college course—upon observing how a certain peer seems to be “getting ahead.”

Resist this anxiety and encourage your child to protect their time at all costs if they want to deeply devote themselves to impressive activities. If you allow them to slip into mimicking their peers' activities, your child will sabotage their admissions odds—the situation they're ironically attempting to avoid by overscheduling.

Here are some additional ways to free up time:

(Note: I recognize that the following pieces of advice are controversial and differ from what you'll hear from most parents, guidance counselors, and other high-achieving but burnt out students. However, they will help your child protect their time and develop a powerful extracurricular profile to stand out and get into the best schools.)

Reducing time spent on homework. You can share the following strategies with your child to help them study smarter—in less time:

- Work in isolation and in a quiet space, such as in a library or at a desk in your house that is away from the computer.
- Avoid using the internet unless it is required. If the internet is required for a certain assignment, use website blockers to avoid spending time perusing social media.
- Do not have your phone near you while studying.

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- Work in 45-50 minute chunks with 5-10 minute breaks.
- Don't spend too much time transitioning between activities. Otherwise, you may get caught up in email, social media, and text messages from friends.
- Eat well. Nutritious meals and snacks will help you be more efficient while completing school work.
- Complete as much work as possible at school.

Eliminating unnecessary courses and reducing workload. Many students think that taking the most difficult course load possible will guarantee them admission to the best universities. They attempt to take every AP and Honors course offered by their school. If your child is already enrolled in AP Biology and they are not terribly passionate about science, they probably should not add AP Physics or AP Chemistry to their schedule. It is perfectly acceptable—and recommended—to take fewer time-consuming courses, especially if it allows time to achieve at an incredibly high level with extracurriculars.

Let's revisit our discussion about "interestingness." Because so many high school students across the country are taking similar courses, taking a school's most challenging courses won't help your child stand out among the applicant pool, even if it does in their own high school community.

If your child is choosing between two different courses to satisfy a requirement that they are not excited about (e.g., a future social scientist who is choosing between AP Biology and AP Psychology), electing the course that is less work or widely viewed as "easier" will not harm their admissions odds because it fits with the overall admissions profile they're looking to develop.

Cutting unnecessary electives can also save time. If your child has enrolled in band, choir, art, or theater and has lost interest, it may be a good time for them to cut that class. In addition to class time, these courses also drain your child's free time after class.

By eliminating unnecessary electives and replacing overly difficult courses with more manageable options, your child can down on class time and gain time to study at school or even leave campus early. More importantly, your child will eliminate hours of unnecessary homework, freeing themselves up to explore their own interests during their evenings and weekends.

Striving for academic success, not perfection. Another problem that many students and parents experience is the desire for perfection: straight A's, only 5's on AP Exams, and perfect or near-perfect ACT or SAT scores.

What surprises many parents is that perfection is no longer the key to acceptance. The occasional A- or B+, a slightly lower score on an AP Exam, or an ACT or SAT score that is closer to the 25th percentile of a college's reported range of test scores are unlikely to be the factors that determine who gets accepted and who gets rejected.

Rather than spend months studying in order to bring an ACT or SAT score up a few points or to bring a B+ up to an A-, your child should spend that time pursuing their artistic, volunteer, or intellectual interests. This is not to say that students should ignore courses and test scores, but at a certain point good enough actually is good enough.

Elite colleges can fill their entire class with students who achieve perfect GPAs, ACT or SAT scores, and countless 5's on AP Exams. Yet, they routinely reject many of these students in favor of applicants with slightly more modest stats but who have innovatively pursued extracurricular activities.

(Note: Trying to stand out through academics falls under the umbrella of “competing in competitive areas” that we discussed earlier. For your child to be seen by elite college as a specialist in academics, they would have to achieve a perfect GPA, ACT or SAT score, SAT Subject Test scores, 5s on as many AP exams their school offers, perhaps achieve As in college courses at well-known universities, and so on. While a minority of students in America will stand out in this way, the enormous time commitment required to be seen as “the best of the best” will detract from other activities *and* leave little to no wiggle room for academic missteps. In other words, it's very risky to attempt standing out in this way.)

Strategy 2: When opportunity knocks, go all in

People who talk about the Sivers article tend to focus on learning how to say “no” more. While it's important to turn down less-than-thrilling options, the second part is learning how to say “Hell yeah!” and to follow through on rare opportunities.

Earlier in this guide I discussed how your child should take incremental small steps in their area of interest so that they can reach the top of the proverbial mountain over time. At times while taking small steps, your child will create or be presented with an exciting opportunity that they are itching to pursue.

When the rare, truly exciting opportunity presents itself, your child should go all in and fully devote their time, attention, and emotion.

For example, if your child has been conducting biology research for two years at your local university and comes across a promising finding that he can write up for a first-author submission to a major journal, he should commit most, if not all, of his extracurricular time to doing so, even if it means taking a break from other activities.

Rare opportunities reflect months or years of hard work. Pursuing them effortfully will lead to outsized achievements and impressiveness when it comes to college applications.

Strategy 3: Build relationships with mentors

After spending some time exploring extracurricular activities and developing new skills, your child will have more clarity about their passions and be ready to take their activities to the next level.

While your child can go it alone, I strongly recommend they connect with a mentor. Mentors are like rocket fuel; they can help your child accelerate their extracurricular progress and achieve greater things during their high school career.

There's no set time your child should seek out a high school mentor, but they should have a certain level of enthusiasm about an idea before doing so. Otherwise, the mentor might feel like they're putting in more effort into a project than your child.

Mentors come in all forms. If your child is interested in pursuing scientific research, a local university professor could be a great mentor. On the other hand, if your child is excited about leading a fundraising project for infants with fetal alcohol syndrome, a

philanthropist or nonprofit organization president could be the right person to guide them.

Reaching out to new organizations and possible mentors can be a daunting task. A good place to start with finding a mentor is through a personal connection, whether teachers, school staff, parents, family members, or family friends.

If a personal contact through these networks does not pan out, your child should consider sending emails to possible mentors with whom they might want to work. Because so many professionals are inundated with emails, this process takes care and patience. In an email to a mentor, students should succinctly state what they're specifically looking for. The email should be personal and address the potential mentor's expertise.

Email to mentor example

Dear Dr. Smith,

I am a high school student at Lakes Community High School (resume attached) with a longstanding interest in bird evolution and migration patterns. I came across your work on the Calliope Hummingbird about a year ago and have been fascinated by how their patterns differ from other birds in their genus.

I'm writing to explore the possibility of joining your lab as an unpaid research assistant because I'm eager to learn from you and to help advance your research. If you're interested, I'd love to know the following:

- 1. What types of duties could I take on as an entry-level research assistant?*
- 2. Are there undergraduate or graduate students who might serve as mentors?*

If you do not have space for a student, do you recommend any reading related to hummingbird evolution or know anyone else who might need a research assistant?

Please let me know if I can provide any additional information. I look forward to hearing from you.

Thanks,

Janet Leonard

If a potential mentor does not respond, your child should wait a week or two before checking in. Here's a sample follow-up email:

Dear Dr. Smith,

I hope this message finds you well. I recognize you're incredibly busy with various projects, but I'm writing to float my previous email to the top of your inbox.

Best,

Janet

If a potential mentor still doesn't respond, that's OK! Some professionals are either super busy or skeptical of mentoring high school students, so your child should move on and find someone who is excited to guide them.

Strategy 4: Form an extracurricular experience

By pursuing paths that are less common, your child's accomplishments will take a different form than what is conventionally seen on college applications.

No matter what your child does, they should dive deeper into a specialized interest, rather than pursue multiple activities superficially. The former often culminates in a project, but it may also result in a series of different activities that constellate around a central interest. Let's explore some ways this might happen.

Project-based approach. Exciting and impressive extracurricular accomplishments can take many forms. It might culminate in writing a book, maintaining a blog, creating a small business, starting an activist movement, or conducting (and publishing) original

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research, to name a few. These types of “passion projects” or “capstone projects” take months—or even years—to complete, and require long-term dedication. A project-based approach does not preclude your child from also pursuing other activities, but could consume substantial time.

Related accomplishments. Many students with an interest in more common activities such as violin, baseball, choir, and theater think that they will not be able to stand out because the standard for being “the best” is exceedingly high—performing or playing professionally.

It may be true that your child is not, empirically speaking, the best at a certain activity, but that does not necessarily mean that they should give up that activity, especially if it continues to interest them. Fortunately, your child does not need to be the best at a given activity for it to be worthwhile from a college admissions standpoint.

Instead, your child can stand out by immersing themselves in other aspects of an activity. Think about pursuing multiple interests or activities in a narrow field of ideas. Succeeding in related activities will make your child look even more successful.

A student with a longstanding interest in music performance might give private music lessons and start an organization that performs shows for low-income or elderly communities. A baseball player might volunteer or work as a coach for a little league team while writing articles for a local newspaper or a website about current events or affairs in baseball. The possibilities are endless. Your child should ask themselves, “What about this activity am I so interested in and how can I explore this interest in a new way?”

Both approaches—project-based or related accomplishments—require curiosity, dedication, and hard work, not special talents. Forget about the idea that successful students are unparalleled geniuses.

Initial successes are often slow and limited. They might come in the form of an unpaid internship or a volunteer position. Oftentimes, these positions require grunt work. A student who serves as a research assistant for a biology project will probably find themselves spending a lot of time looking at bacteria culture or collecting data. A small

business might fail to generate profits. The first draft of a book may require substantial revisions before it is close to being publishable.

The process of getting good at something involves significant practice. Too many students quit activities right before they would have been promoted or otherwise leveled up in skill. Your child should be spending their time on an activity with the aim of improving. The rewards will come.

The good news is that success attracts more success. After your child proves themselves in small ways, they will begin to attract the attention of mentors inside and outside their current organizations. Your child will earn greater responsibilities, solicitations, and avenues for expansion with their developing reputation that they can leverage for more successes.

Take Janet as an example: after Janet was selected to work in Dr. Smith's lab, she spent time compiling and collecting data and working under the supervision of graduate and undergraduate students. After proving herself by spending every Wednesday and Saturday conducting fieldwork, she began analyzing data under the supervision of an advanced graduate student. After learning how to use computer programs to analyze data, Janet began to propose other avenues for further research, which she followed on her own accord with the help of the graduate student. Dr. Smith observed Janet's growth along the way and invited her to submit a first-authored manuscript on her independent project to a noteworthy journal.

The deeper your child goes into an activity area, the greater their achievement is likely to be—and harder to explain. A project that is harder to explain will stand out to admissions committees far more than an accomplishment that is simply hard to do.

Atypical achievements will lead admissions committees to wonder, "How did this applicant reach that position? How did they accomplish each step? Why did the student pursue this interest in the first place?"

Admissions committees are impressed by achievements that are tough to map out or initially understand because they signal that the student has not followed a conventional path.

Summer Activities for High School Students

Many students and parents are concerned about wasting their summer, so they often find themselves taking courses at an elite university, enrolling in summer programs, working part-time jobs, or volunteering at home or abroad. While there's nothing wrong with any of these options, families tend to select activities based on what they think will appear most prestigious and impress admissions committees. Families also mistakenly view summer as being discontinuous from the school year, like they must do something different during the months of June, July, and August.

Every year, admissions readers review applications from students who participated in Harvard summer programs or who went on a mission trip to work at an orphanage in Haiti. Some students even write trite college essays about these experiences in their Common Application or supplemental applications. Unfortunately, courses and trips like these can distract students from their ongoing projects.

Summers indeed provide fantastic opportunities to impress admissions committees. Your child should use these opportunities to explore areas they haven't had time for or, ideally, to go deeper—with far fewer demands on their time—into areas in which they have already demonstrated promise and achievements.

For instance, if your child has been working on a sustainability initiative with her local school district, she may pursue an internship with a sustainability consulting firm and apply her insights to further advance her project. Volunteering at a medical clinic in Thailand for two weeks will not boost her extracurricular profile, especially if she hasn't demonstrated a major commitment to healthcare through other activities.

On the other hand, suppose your child has taught music at schools with no music education funding and has recruited his friends to help grow this project to all middle schools in his mid-sized city's public school district. He could make a connection with another school district—one in the US on a different academic calendar or abroad—to implement the program there on a trial basis over the summer.

If your child is obsessed with physics but lives in a rural community with no advanced school coursework or local colleges, she could certainly enroll in a summer physics program at a well-known university so she can pursue her interest at a higher level.

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Alternatively, she could look to obtain an internship at a company that could use her talents.

Finally, if your child has spent countless volunteer hours designing educational programs for children with autism, working with a nonprofit in Tanzania that aims to eliminate the stigma associated with mental illness would dovetail beautifully with their longstanding commitment.

The takeaway from these diverse experiences is that you should judge the value of a summer opportunity based on how it fits with your child's interests and the extracurricular profile they're working to develop. Disconnected activities are far less impressive.

(Note: Expensive activities or trips do not equate to prestige. Many parents pay thousands upon thousands of dollars so that their students can travel or study abroad or take courses at prestigious universities, thinking that by spending more money on “flashy” activities, they will increase their child's odds of getting into a prestigious university. However, admissions committees notice that the student is attempting to fill out their extracurricular activities carelessly, unless the “flashy” program relates to a larger, overarching interest.)

Frequently Asked Questions

How will my child be able to explain their activities and projects on their application?

Many students worry that working on a niche, idiosyncratic project will adversely affect their application because it can be difficult to fully explain in the Common App Activities Section. Fortunately, your child has the following options to convey their accomplishments to admissions committees:

Letters of recommendation. Your child can share their project with teachers and guidance counselors who, in turn, can write about the projects in their recommendation letters. Your child should explicitly ask their teachers and counselors to discuss appropriate activities.

Common App Essay (i.e., personal statement) or supplemental essays. If a project took substantial time to complete, it may be worth writing about in a reflective matter. Your child can describe how they came to the project or activity and what they learned from it.

Common App Additional Information Section. Unlike an essay, the [Additional Information Section](#) is optional and should not be written in an essay form. It should simply provide a brief explanation—about a paragraph long—of the project.

Interviews. Although not every school requires one, an interview is an excellent time to share the details of an unusual project.

(Side note: Your child should know that it is ok—even recommended—to not fill in each of the ten slots on the Common App Activities section. Admissions officers know that many students fill out this section application to impress them. However, what will impress the admissions committee is a unique, meaningful contribution, not an exorbitant number of activities. There is no harm in leaving insignificant activities off the application, either.

What if my child wants to pursue an extracurricular activity that does not require a huge commitment but is unrelated to their main interest?

A low-commitment extracurricular activity that requires an hour or so of work each week or every other week can be an excellent way to spend time with friends and explore another unrelated interest. This could take the form of volunteering once a week, participating in Model UN, or another club. Your child should select activities with light requirements. They should avoid activities that, from the get-go, require numerous hours of practice and rehearsal each week or activities that require a substantial commitment both in the classroom and after school.

What about spending time with friends? Why should my child pursue a project without his friends, who are all in band and choir? That sounds awfully lonely.

I recognize the value of friendships. However, high schoolers are often so busy that the only time they spend with their friends is during classes, part time jobs, and other activities. Taking the same courses and joining the same low-commitment extracurricular activity are excellent solutions to this dilemma. In addition, collaborating on a project with a friend can be an excellent way to expand the project's scope, given that both students are equally interested in it.

My child's GPA and test scores are not nearly as competitive as other students'. They have started an excellent extracurricular project, but it is already their senior year and I'm afraid my child won't have enough time to complete the project. What should we do? I've heard of taking a "gap year" before applying, but I'm concerned my child will never start college.

If your child's odds of acceptance to their dream school seem slim, a gap year after graduation may be an effective route to take. By advancing a unique, interesting project during this time that fits with the extracurricular profile they built during high school, your child will have a strong chance of standing out, even if their stats are lower than others'.

I like the idea of my child pursuing their own agenda, but I think they would like to make a difference in their school. Do you have any suggestions?

If your child is unsatisfied with their school's extracurricular offerings, starting their own initiative, such as a club or program, can be an excellent way to demonstrate initiative and pursue a particular interest.

Lesson 3

How to Create the Perfect College List

A System for Developing Your Child's School List to Maximize Odds of Acceptance

With over 5,000 colleges and universities in the United States, it may seem overwhelming or impossible to figure out where your child should apply. It's no surprise that so many students wonder, "What college should I go to?"

Of course, you and your child may be familiar with the big-name schools—Harvard, Yale, Stanford, UCLA, etc.—but you may not know what differentiates these schools from one another, nor what other options are available.

Unfortunately, families who are less well-informed about available schools tend to commit one of two major errors while developing their college list:

Applying to too many schools: We've heard stories of students who applied to 25+ schools, hoping they will get in *somewhere* prestigious. This is a poor strategy because the quality of each application will likely decrease with each additional school given limited time and attention.

Applying to familiar schools only: Students will sometimes apply only to their local schools and certain famous schools because those are the only ones they've heard of. These students miss out on applying to schools that would have been just as strong a fit for them, if not better. Sometimes even prestigious universities are unfamiliar to students. For instance, we can't tell you how many times a student interested in attending Harvard or Stanford to study business thought that Penn and UChicago were less prestigious state schools.

The better strategy is to thoroughly research colleges and universities and make well-informed decisions about developing a college list that not only has balance (i.e.,

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“reach”, “target”, and “safety” schools) but also includes only schools that your child would be thrilled to attend. After all, why work so hard for four years just to settle?

To help you navigate the huge world of available US colleges and universities, we’ll highlight what your most important considerations ought to be, in no particular order.

Factor 1: Number of Schools

We already mentioned how applying to a greater number of schools technically increases your admissions odds.

However, when it comes to college admissions—unlike, say, medical school admissions or admissions to certain types of graduate programs—your child is facing the issue of *where* they’ll get in, not *if* they’ll get in somewhere.

We typically recommend creating a school list of 9-12 institutions with the following breakdown:

- **2-3 “safety” schools.** A safety school is one where your child’s GPA and ACT/SAT score exceeds the 75th percentile of admitted students.
- **4-6 “target” schools.** A target school is one where your child’s GPA and ACT/SAT score is somewhere between the 50th and 75th percentile of admitted students.
- **3 “reach” schools.** A reach school is one where your child’s GPA and ACT/SAT score falls between the 25th and 50th percentile of admitted students.
- **[Optional] 1 “far reach” school.** A far reach school is one where your child’s GPA and ACT/SAT score places them below the 25th percentile of admitted students. Please note that is highly unlikely that your child will get into their far reach school.

Note: Highly selective colleges (i.e., those with acceptance rates below 10%, such as Harvard and Stanford) should always be considered a reach or far reach, depending on your child’s academic profile. While an incredible extracurricular profile, superb college essays, and applying early decision or restrictive early action will help boost your child’s admissions odds, these schools routinely reject students with perfect grades and test scores, making it difficult to classify them as a target or safety school.

We'd like to circle back to our previous point about applying only to schools that your child would be excited to attend. We routinely observe students applying to schools—typically safety schools or those in undesirable locations for the student—they have no actual desire to attend. With so many available college and universities, and limited time and attention to apply, there's no reason to include schools that don't appeal.

Note: If your child is applying to University of California (UC) schools, you should feel free to count them as one school or however many you're submitting to because they require a single application with the same essay prompts. (aka, personal insight questions) Our massive article on [How to Write Great UC Application Essays](#) covers the UC application in great detail.

Note: Grades and test scores aren't everything, not even close. Colleges practice holistic admissions, meaning they will strongly consider your child's background, context, extracurricular achievements, and personal factors when making admission decisions. Still, GPA and ACT/SAT scores provide an excellent foundation for classifying schools' competitiveness. Communicating the qualitative factors mentioned above is best done through your child's application essays.

Factor 2: Majors, Programs, and Opportunities

Universities, even those within the same tier, offer significantly different majors, programs, and opportunities to their students that warrant a closer look before your child adds them to their school list.

Majors

For example, take Cornell and Dartmouth, prestigious Ivy League universities in rural settings. If your child is interested in pursuing a career in agriculture or hotel management, Cornell may be the better fit because they offer majors in Agricultural Sciences and Hotel Administration that most other top-tier schools do not.

While your child may change their mind about their major during college, we encourage them to consider some intriguing areas to ensure that the schools on their list can accommodate evolving interests.

Programs

Is your child interested in pursuing journalism, with an eye toward covering news in the Middle East? If so, a school like Northwestern may be an excellent choice given its prestigious Medill School of Journalism and Oman Semester study abroad program.

By identifying specific interests ahead of time your child will be better able to narrow down their school list choices.

Opportunities

We use “opportunities” here as a catch-all term for any extracurricular activities, (e.g., clubs, athletics departments, volunteering) community partnerships, disability support programs, and so on offered by certain schools that your child may be interested in or passionate about.

Factor 3: Cost and Financial Aid

We’ve all heard about the rising costs of attending college in the US and the corresponding debt for many families that take years, sometimes decades, to pay off.

According to The College Board, the cost of college during the 2017-2018 academic year had risen by 26% at private nonprofit four-year colleges since 2007-2008, 37% at public four-year colleges, and 32% at public two-year colleges, after adjusting for inflation.

These increases brought up current prices to the following:

Tuition and Fees

Private nonprofit four-year: \$34,740

Public four-year: \$9,970

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Public two-year: \$3,570

Room and Board

Private nonprofit four-year: \$12,210

Public four-year: \$10,800

Total

Private nonprofit four-year: \$46,950

Public four-year: \$20,770

These numbers can be scary, but they don't tell the entire story. While public universities do indeed have much lower sticker prices, the most selective private colleges, which tend to have the highest endowments (i.e., the wealthiest), also tend to meet the greatest percentage of financial need for families.

In fact, **most students will not have to pay the full listed prices of college tuition, room and board.** Some of this amount will be covered via grants. The rest of it can be covered via loans, work, and scholarships.

Further reading: [The Ultimate Guide to Finding and Winning College Scholarships](#)

Of course, your family may not qualify for need-based aid. If that's the case, you may be more interested in colleges that offer merit-based aid. Keep in mind, however, that the most selective schools, like every Ivy League university, do not offer merit-based aid because all of their students are excellent academically.

There is much more to cover about financial aid that falls outside the scope of this article, but our goal is to introduce the college cost landscape so you can identify colleges that meet your child's academic goals *and* your family's budget.

Factor 4: Location and Size

It's important for your child to consider where they'd like to spend four years of their late teens and early 20s.

Quality of life can matter just as much to students as their academic work. Therefore, we ask students the following questions when helping them develop their school list:

- Do you want to attend school in a big city or rural area?
- Would you like to live in a cold weather or warm weather setting?
- How near to your family do you want to be?

With regard to size, your child's college experience can be very different if the student body comprises 8,000 students vs. 30,000 students. While large colleges make efforts to have small class sizes for upper division courses, access to TAs, community building activities, etc., your child may feel like "just a number" if a large school isn't suited to them.

On the flipside, large colleges sometimes offer opportunities, such as robust athletic departments, that many smaller schools don't. Moreover, your child will have access to a larger pool of students from which to make friends.

There are no right or wrong answers when it comes to location and class size, but we encourage your family to have honest conversations about your child's location and size preferences.

Factor 5: Prestige

Over the past several years, we've noticed a trend where teachers, counselors, and college admissions consultants emphasize the importance of attending colleges that are "the right fit" rather than "the best." Unfortunately, this seems to be a way of curbing families' disappointment if their child doesn't get into their top choices.

We question why "the right fit" and "the best" are presented as mutually exclusive. We believe your child can aim to get into the best schools that are *also* the right fit.

There are advantages to attending America's top colleges: higher earnings potential, possibly stronger alumni networks, powerful brand names on your child's resume, the opportunity to build a family legacy, etc.

While prestige isn't everything, there's a reason why certain schools receive disproportionately larger numbers of applications relative to others. It's not just about your child's education, but also how others will perceive their degree and the sense of achievement that comes with getting in—and graduating from—an elite school.

Final Thoughts

Choosing the right colleges to apply to can mean the difference between a message from your child's dream school that begins with "Congratulations!" and one that says "We regret to inform you..."

Moreover, where your child applies can have a significant financial and personal impact on their next four years and beyond.

Therefore, rather than practicing wishful thinking, taking a data-driven approach to developing your child's school list can help them achieve major admission success—and avoid heartbreak.

Lesson 4

Requesting Standout Recommendation Letters

Whom, when, and how to ask for college recommendation letters

You probably know students or have heard of people with perfect stats and great extracurriculars who didn't get into their dream school. Those cases often come down to submitting mediocre college essays and letters of recommendation (LORs).

Admissions committees want to be able to imagine what your child is like as a person and how they might interact with other students and teachers. If *reviewers* can't picture your child adding value to their campus, they'll be rejected.

Given the importance of LORs, you may start to worry about how your child can obtain top-notch recommendation letters from their teachers. No need! In this lesson, we'll cover whom, how and when your child should ask for the LORs required by their dream schools.

Follow the rules

Your child should always follow the instructions provided by the school.

If the university requests a letter from an academic teacher, your child should send a letter from an academic teacher. If the schools asks for two academic teachers and a third open option, your child should send recommendation letters from two academic teachers and a third from someone who closely supervised their extracurricular activities or an employer who observed their diligence, initiative, and impact.

Following the rules is a surefire way to get off on the right foot.

Choose someone because they know you, not because they are famous

Your child should request recommendation letters from people who know them well.

While it may seem like a good idea to ask a teacher who is an alum of their top-choice school, or a teacher who has celebrity status in your child's community, your child will only benefit if the recommender can write a substantial and persuasive letter about them. If a teacher only knows your child's face and final grade in the course, the letter will likely be underwhelming and generic.

It is best to choose letter writers who know your child as a student and person and who can elaborate on their unique character. Chosen well, your child's LORs will include information about them that isn't found elsewhere on their application.

Think outside the box

When given the open-ended option for letters and feeling uncertain about whom to choose, your child should get creative.

If your child has a coach, adviser or employer who has known them for some time and can speak articulately on their behalf, perhaps they are a good choice. In addition, instructors who know your child through an extracurricular activity (as opposed to an academic course) can often provide a unique perspective that may not come up inside the classroom.

Main point: unless specified by the school, don't rule out adults just because they haven't taught your child inside the classroom.

Stay current

It is best for your child to choose recommenders from their current school year or a year prior, unless they've maintained a great relationship with a teacher from an earlier grade level.

A teacher who knew your child freshman year and has not interacted with them since? Pass. On the other hand, a teacher who met your child freshman year and has mentored them since? Compelling choice.

When to ask for a letter of recommendation

Your child should request recommendation letters *at least* two months before their application deadlines and be clear about when their college application deadlines are.

If your child happens to know they would like to ask a particular teacher well in advance, they could let them know early on that they hope to get a LOR from them.

Remember, teachers are often inundated with LOR requests 2-3 months prior to application deadlines. Asking in advance means your child's teacher won't be rushed and will be more likely to *submit* a stronger letter.

(Further reading: [The Ideal College Application Timeline](#))

How to ask for a letter of recommendation

Ask in person, whenever possible. Even if your child initially sends an email to set up the meeting, an in-person request is always preferable to an email request. The latter may appear less invested and less mature.

Here is a sample email to request the letter in person:

Dear [Teacher's Name],

I hope all is well with you. I'm applying to college this upcoming year and am hoping you would offer your perspective on the process as I've always valued your guidance. If so, please let me know some days/times that work well for you to meet, and I'll make sure to accommodate. Thank you for your time and consideration!

Best,

[Your Name/Last Name]

If asking in person is not an option, here is a sample script for the recommendation letter request email:

Dear [Teacher's Name],

I hope all is well with you. I'm applying to college this upcoming year and am wondering whether you'd feel comfortable writing a strong letter of recommendation. [Authentic sentence explaining why you would value a letter from them (ex. why you value their perspective, etc.)]. If you're willing to provide a letter, I will provide the following materials: 1) a list of my grades 2) my CV, 3) a draft of my personal statement, and 4) the school's guidelines for letters of recommendation. Thank you for your time and consideration!

Best,

[Your Name/Last Name]

Ask for a *strong* letter of recommendation

If your child is unsure whether or not an adult will write a compelling recommendation, they should ask the recommender if they would feel comfortable providing a “strong letter of recommendation.” If a teacher seems hesitant, your child should simply thank them and move on to the next. Better to suffer that minor rejection than end up with a weak LOR and lower admissions odds.

If your child is not confident that an adult will write a positive recommendation, *don't ask them*. Remember, the admissions committee is evaluating *your child*, not the person writing the letter. Your child's relationship with the recommender outweighs their background or perceived status.

What to provide the letter writer

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Your child should offer to provide their recommenders with application materials or a short list of notable accomplishments (sometimes referred to as a “brag sheet”), should they wish to look them over. Many teachers with stacks of letters to write will decline; however, it is wise to offer. Materials to provide include:

- a finalized personal statement or advanced draft
- a list grades (a transcript copy will do)
- a CV or resume
- any specific instructions from the school requesting the LOR

Waive the right to view your letters of recommendation

By this point, you’re likely convinced about the importance of LORs, have a solid idea of whom your child should request them from, and how to do so politely. However, you may still be wondering, “Should *my child* waive the right to examine this letter of recommendation?” Anxiety about sending an unread LOR to your child’s top school is *completely normal*. After all, LORs are the only part of your child’s application that you cannot see prior to sending.

However, your child should *waive* their right to see LORs on their application when prompted. Otherwise, schools will not trust the letters, as they assume teachers are less honest with their commentary when they know their letter will be reviewed by the student.

How to follow up before the deadline

Say your child has requested LORs in advance, but a month has passed and they haven’t heard from their writer or the school regarding submission. Your child is probably anxious to reach out, but concerned about annoying someone who is doing them a favor.

The good news? It is completely acceptable to reach out to recommenders with a reminder. In fact, they are probably expecting it! Your child should follow up with their recommenders about two weeks to a month prior to their first application deadline to

express gratitude and ensure their letters have been (or are about to be) sent. Here's a sample letter of recommendation follow-up email:

Dear [Teacher's Name],

I hope all is well with you. I plan to submit my college applications [on date or in # of days/weeks], so I'm sending a reminder regarding your recommendation letter. Please let me know if there is any additional information I can provide.

Thank you for all of your support!

Best,

[Your Name/Last Name]

Thanking the recommender

Once your child has heard back from schools and has made a decision on where to attend, it's important that they send a thank you note to recommenders updating them on their admissions results and decision on where they'll be attending.

Your child's letter writers will be grateful to hear their decision directly. A hand-written thank you note will add an extra mature touch.

Here's a sample thank you letter for your child's recommendation writers:

Dear [Teacher's Name],

Thank you again for supporting my college applications by offering your perspectives on the process and submitting a recommendation letter. I wanted to let you know that I was accepted to [school name] and plan to attend in the Fall!

I feel very fortunate to have great mentors like you. Thank you, again, for all of your support.

Best,

[Your Name/Last Name]

What makes a good letter of recommendation

Specific examples/anecdotes

Specific examples and anecdotes are key components of a persuasive LOR, as they tell the admissions committee that the writer truly knows your child and can provide examples to back up the claims they are making.

Generic: *George is a brilliant student and has a clear passion for chemistry.*

Specific: *George is a brilliant student who has a clear passion for chemistry. It came as no surprise that in addition to being the best student in my class, he also scored a 5 on the AP exam. I was continually impressed by George's zest for chemistry and his involvement in not one, but two different science clubs on campus.*

Clear/powerful language

Powerful language and the use of superlatives tell the admissions committee that your child's writer feels strongly about just how wonderful they are. Rather than imply your child is as good a candidate as any other, this kind of language states that they are superior to other candidates and should be viewed as such.

Vague/generic: *Sally wrote good essays during her time in my AP English course and was always friendly with her peers.*

Clear/powerful: *Sally's essays during her time in my AP English course were some of the most compelling I've read in 16 years of teaching. In addition, she was an absolute pleasure to have in class and beloved by all of her peers.*

Enthusiastic support

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A recommendation and an enthusiastic recommendation read quite differently. You want your child's writer to convince the admissions committee that they should accept them or they will be sorely missing out. Enthusiastic support tells the committee that your child doesn't just deserve *not* to be rejected (pardon the double negative), but rather that they deserve to be accepted and valued.

Unenthusiastic support: *I recommend John be accepted to your undergraduate program. If you have questions, please contact me.*

Enthusiastic support: *I give John my highest recommendation, as I know he will continue to excel in college and beyond. It was my pleasure to serve as his teacher and I am confident that he will add great value to your university. Please do not hesitate to contact me with any questions.*

Insight into your child's personality, not just their grades

You already know that your child's dream school is looking for an outstanding GPA as well as ACT, SAT, and other test scores, but they also want to know more.

As discussed earlier, schools want to know who your child is as a person, not just as a student. A recommendation letter that fails to address this will leave them wondering: does the student have a negative (or no) personality? Does this teacher not really know them, just their name and final grade?

Grades only: *Sonia performed impressively in my course and was well known for her academic prowess on campus.*

Additional insight: *Sonia performed impressively in my course and was well known for her academic prowess on campus as well as her kind spirit. For instance, I routinely observed Sonia outside the cafeteria helping sign up peers for volunteer work with several of the organizations she championed. Sonia's work with Heal The Bay often came up in class discussion, making her passion for the environment undeniable.*

Sample College Recommendation Letter

Dear Admissions Committee,

I had the pleasure of teaching Leah Watkins in her 11th grade AP English Literature class at Fitzgerald High School. From the beginning, Leah impressed me with her passion for literature and her ability to understand and articulate difficult concepts. Leah is incredibly insightful and skilled in picking up nuances and subtleties within the text. In addition to achieving an A+ in my notoriously difficult class and a 5 on the AP exam, I am not surprised to find out that Leah is now ranked at the top of perhaps the most capable senior class in our school's 65-year history.

Leah is an active and engaging student, who participated frequently in class and routinely supported her peers. Throughout the year, she provided her peers with a safe space to share their opinions and receive helpful feedback. Even when others' opinions differed from her own, Leah was open, compassionate and kind. During a class debate about abortion, Leah offered to speak for the side opposite her own views in order to practice putting herself in others' shoes. Leah's warmth and empathy as a person enhance her skills as a writer and make her a true joy to have in the classroom.

Outside of the classroom, Leah demonstrated a passion and talent for poetry as the president of the Fitzgerald Poetry Club during sophomore and junior year. As president, Leah seamlessly combined her skills as a poet with her natural leadership abilities. Leah's kindness and openness to feedback made her a beloved president, and I imagine she will be greatly missed by her younger peers upon graduation.

Leah has my highest recommendation for admission to your undergraduate program. I have no doubt that she will continue to do great things in the future and will be a valuable member of your community. Please feel free to contact me with any questions.

Sincerely,

Stacy Moore

Fitzgerald High School

Lesson 5

How to Write an Amazing Common App Essay

**Learn step-by-step how to write a Common App Essay
that dazzles the admissions committee**

If college admissions committees could not see your child's grades, standardized test scores, extracurricular activities, or recommendation letter, what would your child want them to know?

What is The Common Application?

You might be familiar with The Common Application, Common App for short, which serves as a single application that over seven-hundred colleges, including every Ivy League school (e.g., Harvard, Yale, Princeton) and Stanford, share. The Common App allows you to fill out things like your name, demographics, extracurricular activities, and more, just once for every school that uses it. It is also where you'll encounter "The Common App Essay," otherwise known as the personal statement (PS), which is what this lesson will focus on.

Though not every school uses the Common App—many state or public schools often have their own systems—the work your child does in writing the Common App Essay will serve them in every other component of the process, including non-Common App schools (e.g., University of California [UC] schools) as well as the secondary and supplemental essays that go along with the Common App. (Schools that don't use Common App may still ask for essays or short answers.)

Why does The Common App Essay—and other college essays—matter?

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You may have heard the phrase “holistic” admissions thrown around—many universities follow this model, which means they don’t necessarily have an ACT or SAT cutoff score, nor do they require a certain number of AP/IB/Honors courses. Instead, they’re trying to get to know candidates as humans. Admissions officers are people—people who would be horribly bored if their job came down just to numbers, statistics, cutoffs, and counting up your AP and SAT and ACT scores.

In order to get into their dream school, your child will need not only great grades and test scores but also a strong personal statement. Why? The Personal Statement is the single loudest ‘qualitative’ element of your application. It brings to life the applicant behind the statistics and demographics. It’s the way your child communicates with the admissions committee as a person and as a potential member of the campus community. With more people applying to colleges every year, admissions officers know they can have their pick of bright and motivated students. In addition to seeing your child’s talents and achievements on paper, they need a chance to imagine what your child might be like as a walking, talking human being.

Many students and parents wonder how big of a role essays play when it comes to college admissions decisions. While the importance of college essays—which are written over a period of a few weeks or (ideally) a few months—varies from school to school, most experts estimate that they make up for anywhere from 10-30% of admissions decisions! In other words, four years of schoolwork, AP, IB, ACT, and SAT exams, community service, volunteering, etc. account only for 70-90%. These estimates are provided not to scare you, but rather to emphasize how critical it is for your child to spend at least as much time on your college essays as they would on any other high school pursuit.

Fortunately, we’re going to talk about every aspect of your personal statement in this lesson, and reflect on some of the lessons we’ve taken from over a decade of coaching students through the college application process and getting into their dream schools.

What are these mystical college essays, anyway?

Let’s define our terms—

Personal Statement (PS): when people refer to the personal statement, they're talking about the 650-word Common Application Essay which all schools using the Common App will see. The Personal Statement provides the admissions committee with an opportunity to get to know your child as a person. Throughout this lesson, "Common App Essay," "Common App personal statement," and "personal statement" are used interchangeably.

Secondary or supplemental essays: these are the school-specific essays that your child will submit on top of the core Common App Essay. They might invite your child to talk more about an extracurricular activity on their resumé, or to reflect on a quote from a famous alumna/alumnus of the college

Here are the 2019-2020 Common App Essay Prompts (they're the exact same ones as last year and typically change little from year to year)—and we'll address how to think about them shortly, so just lodge them in your brain for now.

- Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.
- The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?
- Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?
- Describe a problem you've solved or a problem you'd like to solve. It can be an intellectual challenge, a research query, an ethical dilemma—anything that is of personal importance, no matter the scale. Explain its significance to you and what steps you took or could be taken to identify a solution.
- Discuss an accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked a period of personal growth and a new understanding of yourself or others.
- Describe a topic, idea, or concept you find so engaging that it makes you lose all track of time. Why does it captivate you? What or who do you turn to when you want to learn more?
- Share an essay on any topic of your choice. It can be one you've already written, one that responds to a different prompt, or one of your own design.

Broad, right? In just 650 words, your child must articulate what moves them, excites them, or even explains them.

This means the essays are not a place to restate what can already be found on your child's resumé, CV, or Common App Activities Section. They're also not a place to prove that your child has had some major epiphany, changed the world, seen the Truth of reality, etc, at eighteen. They can be but do not have to be—by any means—about a major traumatic experience. They can but need not discuss family, identity, race, gender, or class. They are a place to give the admissions committee a chance to see the person that friends, classmates, teachers, teammates, and family know. We've seen students write about the New England Patriots, the poetry of John Keats, their grandparents' village, their obsession with keeping too many Google Chrome tabs open, how grilling meats represented a rite of passage, and many more topics that range from the super-serious to the lighthearted but still meaningful.

(Note: The Common App Essay prompts are diverse enough that they allow you to write about pretty much anything. Therefore, we encourage applicants to brainstorm their best stories first and *then* think about which question to answer. Admissions committees have no preference for which prompt is chosen.)

Let's meet our students

Throughout this lesson, we're going to refer to a few example essays. Some of these are made up but others are closely based on essays we have worked with students on over the past ten-plus years—and these students successfully met their admissions goals, including getting into multiple Ivy League and other top-tier schools. Let's meet our students now!

Student #1: Ramya: Ramya intends to be pre-med in college, but isn't sure if she wants to major in biology or something else entirely. She's spent her high school years participating in a variety of activities. She played soccer, but wasn't the star player. She was involved in student government, performed in cultural shows as a dancer, and did speech events.

What's not on Ramya's resumé? She is a rabid fan of the New England Patriots, despite living in California for most of her life. And she's very close to her father and has a tight-knit group of friends.

Student #2: Anita: Anita has an aptitude for English and history. She likes writing, but she's not on the school newspaper, nor has she ever published a piece of fiction or poetry, which makes her nervous about calling herself a writer. She spends much of her time on mock trial—in fact she's nationally competitive at it—and lots of people tell her she'd make a great lawyer. But she doesn't think she wants to major in political science or philosophy; she may not even want to do anything associated with mock trial in college.

What's not on her resumé? She loves the outdoors, though she has nothing concretely extracurricular to prove it—she's never been a camp counselor or a Girl Scout.

Student #3: Josh: Josh isn't sure what he wants to study. He's a solid student, though no particular subject gets his pulse racing. In his free time he draws comic strips, and he's had a few on display at various community events in his town. He plays basketball and piano.

What's not on his resumé? Josh has a complicated relationship with piano—his parents pushed him into it, and he'd like to quit as soon as possible. And he's very close to his big brother, who recently left for college. He also has a little sister, who he's never been tight with.

Student #4: Michael: Michael lives in a small coastal town and attends a big public high school. After school he has a job scooping ice cream, and though he's not expected to contribute to his family's income, he doesn't have much time for clubs or sports, which aren't very important at his school. He generally likes chemistry, but he isn't sure what he wants to do with that. He doesn't want to be pre-med, and he can't imagine being a chemist, so he's undecided about what to major in.

What's not on his resumé? Michael is no great surfer by competitive standards, but he learned how to stand up on a board at a young age because his grandfather, who's from Hawaii, taught him. His grandfather recently passed away.

Pre-writing

Of course, one of the biggest challenges when writing—whether you’re a professional, seasoned author or a high schooler planning for college—is figuring out where to start.

Students applying to college are full of passion and potential energy which hasn’t yet been converted into kinetic energy. How can they come across as intelligent without sounding like they’re trying too hard?

The best antidote to all of these concerns, from writer’s block to finding your voice, is to prepare yourself emotionally and creatively before sitting down to write the personal statement.

Here’s how your child can attack the Common App personal statement and secondary essays months before they’re due. We are big proponents of starting early—ideally in June. Why?

Your child may not be thrilled at the prospect of spending the summer before senior year on college applications. But starting in June after junior year and committing to a few exercises over the summer will be like spring training for summer athletes. By the time August arrives, your child will be warmed up, and much of the hardest work—that is, the reflection, figuring out what to say—will be done.

(Bonus: starting early will also give your child time to hand a strong draft of their essay to the teachers from whom you plan to request letters of recommendation for college. If your child’s recommenders can preview the draft, they can write a letter that aligns with the story. This is crucial because your application is a chance to offer not only the facts about you but also a narrative of you—a sense of who you are, how you move through the world, and what you hope to become. That means each component of your application—your Common App personal statement, your [supplemental college essays](#), your teacher recommendations, the classes you’ve taken—is a kind of episode in the story.)

But, we’ve offered some adjusted timelines lower down in case your child doesn’t have the whole summer to work with.

Brainstorming essay topics and working with prompts (2-3 weeks)

Your child should review the Common App prompts and identify which ones get their juices flowing. You can also use our expanded prompts to help your child brainstorm and freewrite over the summer. We're starting with Common App Essay Prompt #7, since it is the broad, general question. Then we'll circle back and go through #s 1-6.

Prompt 7. Share an essay on any topic of your choice. It can be one you've already written, one that responds to a different prompt, or one of your own design.

- Make a list of themes and broad topics that matter to you. What do you, your friends, and family spend a lot of time thinking about or talking about? (Note: this is not the same as asking for list of extracurricular activities.) Tell the story of an important day or event in relation to one of these topics.
- Who's a family member who lives with you and is important to you? Think of a specific time they helped you with something. Tell the story. What's an important conversation you had with them? Tell the story.
- Think of any person—family, friend, teacher, etc—who has been important to you. When did you first meet them? Tell the story. When did you have a crucial, meaningful, or important conversation with them? Tell the story.
- Make a list of experiences that have been important to you. These do not have to be dramatic, tragic, traumatic, or prove that you changed the world, though they can be any of those. Perhaps a particular summer that mattered a lot? Or an experience with a friend or family member who shaped you—it could be a specific day spent with them, or a weekend, a summer, a year?

(Remember: Specific anecdotes are useful when drafting your Common App personal statement. Try to think of a story you often tell people that shows something about you. One of the best pieces of advice we can give you—and something you'll see reflected in all of the following prompts—is to anchor things in anecdote or story as much as possible.)

Prompt 1. Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.

- Where did you grow up? Describe your neighborhood, town, or community. Big or small? What makes it unlike other parts of the world? How has it affected you? What images are important for someone who has never been to your hometown/neighborhood/community to see? For instance, is there farmland all around you, grain silos, cows? A Chick-Fil-A every block?
- Where is home for your parents? Does their home impact your day-to-day life? Describe the first time you saw their home, in story form.
- Did you grow up considering another place that is not where you currently live home? Tell the story of the first time you went there or the first time you remember going there. Was there a particular time—a summer, or a year—when that place became important? Tell that story.
- What's the most memorable thing about you? What do people in your community or school know you for? Tell the story of the first time you did this thing. Tell the story of the most meaningful time you did this thing—it might be, say, when you won a game, but it also might be when you lost a game, or when you quit the team.
- How have you spent your summers in high school? In childhood? Tell a story of a memorable day during a memorable summer. Where were you? Why did it matter? Does what happened that day influence you today? How?

Prompt 2. The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?

- What major changes have you been through? A move? Changing schools? Losing a loved one or a friend? (Avoid writing about romantic relationships and breakups in your essays, but feel free to mine them in your freewriting.) Tell the story of the day that change occurred—the day you moved, the first day at the new school or the last day at the old school, the day you got bad news about a family member or a friend, etc.
- Did you ever quit an extracurricular activity or a job? Why? Tell the story of the day that happened, and of the day you decided to quit.

- What class was hardest for you in high school? Why? Tell the story of a specific class assignment that was difficult. Now tell the story of a specific class assignment that caused you to have a breakthrough, or changed your mind about something.
- Have you ever been forced to try something you weren't good at? How'd it go? Tell the story of the day you tried it. Who encouraged you to? Where were you?
- Have you faced a disability, a mental or physical health issue, or other significant challenge while in high school? Think of a day when you are proud of how you handled or carried yourself in the face of this challenge. (Recommended reading: [How to Effectively Write About a Disability in a College Essay](#))

Prompt 3. Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?

- What values did you grow up holding dear? Are they the same ones today? Tell the story of the first time you learned about these values—say, a morning at Sunday School or a conversation with a grandparent. If they've changed, tell the story of the moment (as best you can place it) when they changed—say, in a classroom, in a conversation with a friend, etc.
- Is there a prevalent belief in your family or community with which you disagree? How did you come to disagree? Tell the story of an argument—cordial or not—that you've had with someone about this issue. Tell the story of a time you are proud of how you handled conflict in relation to this disagreement.
- When were you wrong about something? Tell the story of how you figured out you were wrong. Who helped you get there?

Prompt 4. Describe a problem you've solved or a problem you'd like to solve. It can be an intellectual challenge, a research query, an ethical dilemma—anything that is of personal importance, no matter the scale. Explain its significance to you and what steps you took or could be taken to identify a solution.

- What class assignments have gotten you thinking hardest? Tell the story of one of them.
- What books or articles have you read that caused you to identify something wrong in the world? What did you learn from those, and what did they/do they make you want to do? Tell the story of reading that book/article for the first time—where were you? Who handed it to you? Who did you discuss it with afterward? How often have you reread that meaningful book or article?

- Is there a problem that comes up over the dinner table with your family regularly? How do you think about solving it as a family, or individually? Tell the story of one of those dinners. Tell the story of another dinner, if you'd like!
- What makes you angry or furious about the world? Tell the story of a time you saw something—visually—that provoked that anger or frustration. Describe images and your reactions.

Prompt 5. Discuss an accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked a period of personal growth and a new understanding of yourself or others.

- They say a piece of short fiction is about a moment after which nothing will be the same again. Have you lived through one of those moments? What was it? Tell it the way you'd write a short story.
- Eureka! Have you ever had a moment when everything just *clicked*? Tell the story of that realization—set the scene, down to every image, who was or wasn't in the room.
- Forget medals, victories, grades—what intangible, off-your-resumé quality or moment of your life are you proudest of? Tell the story of the day that happened.

Prompt 6. Describe a topic, idea, or concept you find so engaging that it makes you lose all track of time. Why does it captivate you? What or who do you turn to when you want to learn more?

- Let's say you're left alone an entire weekend in your house. What do you get up to? Tell the story of a time that's happened—or imagine, on the page, what that would be like. Set the scene: what rooms are you in in your house, or are you in your house at all? Where do you go? What do you bring with you?
- What activities have you self-started—that is, what have you done without ever being told to? Tell the story of the first day you started doing that thing.
- What do your friends come to you seeking help with? Tell the story of a time when you think you did a great job of helping another person. Now, to make sure you stay humble, tell the story of when that person helped you.

At the end of this brainstorming exercise, our students, Ramya, Anita, Josh, and M, will have discovered even more things not on their resumé that can expand what all they might write about.

Freewriting (3-4 weeks)

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Before writing a draft or even selecting a prompt, your child should freewrite using the above prompts as a guide.

Freewriting is one of the fun parts, so the more opportunities to do so, the better.

Your child should sound authentic in their essay—they don't want to stiffen up under pressure, as many students do, in an attempt to sound formal, more stereotypically "adult" or "learned." The more your child can sound like themselves, the better their personal statement will be.

Here are some strategies your child can use to make the most of the freewriting process:

Buy a few composition notebooks: Why? Take the cartoonist Lynda Barry's wise words here: "There is a kind of story that comes from hand. Writing which is different from a tapping-on-a-keyboard-kind-of-story. For one thing, there is no delete button, making the experience more lifelike right away. You can't delete the things you feel unsure about and because of this, the things you feel unsure about have a much better chance of being able to exist long enough to reveal themselves."

Set aside six minutes each morning, or a few times a week, for freewriting. Six minutes, that's it! Put your timer on, put your pen to paper, and don't stop writing until the timer goes off. If you run out of things to write, write "I don't know I'm bored I don't know help help I hate writing!" until new words come. What are you going to write about during those six minutes? You can try thinking about those Common App essay prompts—they're so broad that they should let you in in some way: what's my obstacle, my identity, the thing I love? Note that Anita isn't sitting down to write her disquisition on How my life as a mock trial champion makes me prepared to go to law school. Instead, what might come out as she writes by hand is... I remember the rush the first time I stood up at a mock trial tournament. I was wearing a blazer and my mom's heels and they were so uncomfortable. It was so overheated in the room and I'd drunk way too much Mountain Dew. But why did I love playing this role of attorney? Was it the theater? The chance to finally argue without getting in trouble at the dinner table? If six minutes doesn't work for you, or if you think you're not getting in the zone in

that amount of time, try doing three pages in your composition notebook instead. Write in big letters and double-space. Let your hand roam free.

Don't show anyone anything you have written yet. And don't reread it immediately. Let all that you've written sit, latent, so you're not tempted to edit it right off the bat. Why? Allowing your writing to breathe away from you can prevent you from committing one of the cardinal sins of personal statement-writing—but also all writing!—trying to force the story into what you think it should be instead of what it is. To get more concrete: let's say Michael wrote about his grandfather teaching him to surf in answer to several of those prompts—about a crucial summer, and an important person to him. But now he's so excited about that that he immediately wants to turn it into his draft. As he's writing, he gets self-conscious, thinking: why am I writing about surfing when I'm not a competitive surfer, and when it's only something I do occasionally? Or say Michael shows it to an English teacher, who gets distracted by the quality of Michaels prose—which was meant to be free and unedited—and tells him to choose another topic, since this one isn't "singing" yet. Respect your process and let these things sit.

In order to have this kind of time freedom, your child should start early. And if they spend summer warming up and training for the main event, they can start rereading their body of freewriting by the end of July.

Essay writing timelines: how to write a Common App Essay if you have six months, three months, one month, or even less

(Recommended reading: [The Ideal College Application Timeline](#))

Writing college essays the summer before your senior year is ideal. However, many students have prior commitments that make following a six-month (June-December) timeline difficult. So here are a few adjusted timelines that can allow your child to take advantage of the brainstorming and freewriting process even if they don't have the full six-month window.

Six months - June to December (ideal for [early action or early decision](#) applications):

- June: Brainstorm and work with prompts, 2-3 weeks

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- July: Freewrite, 3-4 weeks
- End of July/beginning of August: Complete first draft of Common App personal statement
- Week two of August: Complete second draft (here is where the major revision work comes in)
- Weeks three-four of August: Complete third and fourth drafts
- Beginning of September: Seek feedback from a trusted admissions counselor, English teacher, or other advisor
- End of September: Complete final draft

During October, your child should complete their secondary essays. (November is usually when early action/early decision deadlines hit). The last few weeks of November should be spent completing any remaining secondary essays for schools with December or January due dates (most regular decision deadlines).

Three months - August to October (barely making the early application/early decision deadline):

- First two weeks of August: Brainstorm and work with prompts
- Second two weeks of August: Freewrite
- First week of September: Complete first draft of Common App personal statement
- Week two of September: Complete second draft (here is where the major revision work comes in)
- Weeks three-four of September: Complete third and fourth drafts
- Beginning of October: Seek feedback from a trusted admissions counselor, English teacher, or other advisor
- Week two of October: Complete final draft

The second two weeks of October can be used to complete secondary essays for any school with a November due date, and the rest of November can be spent finishing any remaining secondary essays for schools with December and January due dates (most regular decision deadlines).

One month - October to November (for regular decision schools):

- First week of October: Brainstorm and work with prompts
- Second week of October: Freewrite
- Third week of October: Complete first draft of Common App personal statement

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- Last week of October: Complete second draft (here is where the major revision work comes in)
- First two weeks of November: Complete third and fourth drafts
- Mid-November, before Thanksgiving break: Seek feedback from a trusted admissions counselor, English teacher, or other advisor
- Last week of November: Complete final draft

December should be spent completing any remaining secondary essays for schools with December and January due dates (most regular decision deadlines)

Mega crunch time - Starting in November (in case your child gets started on their application really late and has less than one month, use the following timeline):

- 2-4 days: Brainstorm and work with prompts
- 2-3 days: Freewrite
- 48 hours after freewriting ends: Complete first draft of Common App personal statement
- 72 hours after first draft: Complete second draft. (here is where the major revision work comes in) In addition, seek feedback between second and third drafts, from a trusted admissions counselor, English teacher, or other advisor
- 48 hours after receiving feedback: Complete third draft
- 48 hours after third draft, if time permits: Complete fourth and final draft

(Note: Some elite public universities, such as UC Berkeley and UCLA, have November application deadlines. Therefore, it's important that your child develop their college list, with deadlines and requirements, by the end of September to ensure that applications are submitted on time. Further reading: [How to Write Great UC Application Essays](#))

Choosing a Common App Essay topic

With all this free-written raw material in hand, it's time to choose the right topic. What notes should your child's essay hit? Here are some characteristics that a good Common App Essay topic contains:

1. Anecdote and specificity. As you saw in the prompts above, we're big advocates of beginning with a particular story or anecdote. This is NOT the only way to start an essay, but it's a classic one. Journalists call this a "lede"—it's a

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hook that brings the reader into a wider topic. The essay will always go beyond the anecdote, but an anecdote offers a reader an easy, smooth way into your personal statement.

A good Common App Essay topic can relate, as much as possible, to a particular anecdote, story, or even scene. Let's say Josh found himself writing about his siblings—his older brother who just left for college, and his little sister who he's spent more time with since his brother left. His essay shouldn't start, "I love my little sister," but "I remember the first time my younger sister and I connected. It was July, and our older brother had just gone to college, leaving the two of us alone at home together for the first time."

A good essay begins at a specific point in time and revolves around a specific event. An essay without an anecdote or specific story is an essay TOPIC, not an essay. Your child should pull from their freewriting: where did they find themselves writing about a particular event, story, anecdote, or point in time?

Another way of thinking about this is: does the chosen anecdote contain a person, a setting, and a beginning/middle/end? That gives you a character, a place, and a plot—all crucial elements of a story.

One important note is that your child doesn't have to start with the anecdote—it doesn't have to be the "lede." But you'll want one to work with, to anchor the piece at some point.

2. Tension, conflict, and opportunity to show growth. Josh might write a lovely reflection on how close he and his brother were, or how much he likes his little sister—but that doesn't give the admissions committee much to work with. Why? Because the essay needs to display your ability to grow, to show change over a period of time. If Josh has always had a perfect relationship with his sister, well—first, no one will believe that, and second, Josh is not really telling a story. So as your child identifies the right anecdote for their essay, they should ensure they have a point of tension—a point where we, the reader, wonder if everything will turn out okay. For J, this might mean beginning with a time before he and his sister were close—say, when all the siblings were in the house and there wasn't

much time for the two to connect. Then Josh would tell us about what changed as soon as the brother left, and in there he might find an opening anecdote.

3. A wider relevance or a ‘lesson.’ Your child’s essay doesn’t have to demonstrate that they underwent some great metamorphosis or epiphany, but does the topic have a takeaway to work with? You’re looking for something that you can put in your pocket and carry into the future, and in an impressive and ideal world, something that the reader of the essay can say: “wow, I like that way of thinking, and I might even return to that one day.”

Another way of thinking about this is: the essay is about how past experiences have shaped the applicant’s way of thinking. Michael has settled on his grandfather teaching him to surf: That’s a fruitful topic—not just because it contains two characters (Michael and his grandfather), but also a place (the ocean, or, say, a surf shop), a plot (Michael couldn’t surf in the beginning, then learned in the middle, now at the end Michael can surf and tell us about it), but also because the end includes a lesson and a chance to spin that forward, perhaps by talking about how the sport has taught Michael how to be calm and collected under pressure.

4. Some connection between the past, present, and future. It’s common to see a student choose an important experience in their past, narrate the whole thing beautifully, but then forget to tie it to the present. Before your child starts writing, they should think about whether the experience they want to discuss informs their career goals, way of thinking, etc.. Take Michael, again. He writes beautifully about his grandfather teaching him about the waves, but he’s not a pro surfer, and might even be going to college in the middle of the country. Does that matter? Not as long as he tells us how surfing influences him—as he did in extracting a wider lesson.

Your child might be afraid of picking “the wrong topic.” Students often ask us: Should I not write about a dying grandparent? About coming out? About the meaning of my name? About politics?

Here's a secret: the success of the topic almost always lies in the delivery—so absent writing about something flagrantly offensive, violent, or irresponsible, no topic is off-limits.

It is good to be afraid of cliché—but one of the truisms about clichés is that they become trite because they reiterate feelings we've all had. That also means that buried beneath many clichés is an authentic, particular, and personal relationship to the topic. Your child's teacher, counselor, or advisor can help discern whether their writing is in cliché territory or a more fruitful realm.

It's also important to remember to demonstrate humility.. Your child shouldn't try so hard to sound adult, or beyond their years, that they end up coming across as a know-it-all. It's better to show the admissions committee that they are capable of finding and making meaning through the experiences they've had as a young person, no matter how small or limited they may seem. If you'll let us wax philosophical for a moment: that ability to make meaning from something that isn't pompous or dramatic—and to do so without being aggrandizing—is the stuff of great art. A humble and honest approach to writing always works best.

So now, your child should **make a list of everything that seems like a fruitful topic**. From the questions and prompts, they should aim to find 3-5 strong topic areas and stories—stuff that got them thinking and feeling, and which produced what Hemingway called the “honest sentences” that comprise good writing. The one that moves them the most should be reserved for the personal statement; the others can be used for supplementary essays

Let's find out what our sample students chose to write about.

Essay #1: Ramya on the Patriots

Ramya could try to write something about medicine. Or she could write about soccer, dance, or speech. But none of those things seem to tell the admissions committee what they wouldn't already know from simply reading her list of extracurriculars.

So we decide that Ramya is going to write about the Patriots. The question is how she's going to demonstrate—through her football fandom—that she is a mature and

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thoughtful person who will be a good member of any college's community. An Ode to Brady won't do the trick here—but what will is Ramya's thoughtful reflection on how spending time watching the Patriots at a sports bar every Sunday with her dad has helped her cultivate a relationship with her father that most of her friends have never enjoyed with their families.

Essay #2: Anita on the outdoors + poetry

The obvious thing—and the thing most teachers and advisors told Anita to do—is write about mock trial. It would be a good opportunity to give the admissions committee some insight into her psychology behind the success. She took a couple of stabs at it during free-writing, though, and it didn't flow.

So instead Anita decides to write about a wilderness solo she took in North Carolina on a school trip, and about how it influenced her relationship with poetry.

Essay #3: Josh on piano and mistakes

We talked a lot about whether Josh would do best avoiding writing about piano—it's the main thing on his resumé and sometimes it can be good to show things off-resumé, as Ramya and Anita plan to. Josh did some writing about his relationship with his sister and his brother, and that might find a home in the secondary essays. But it became clear that Josh has an obsessive, if not always positive, relationship with piano, and so there's something there.

But how to write “about piano?”

We look at the themes that came up during Josh's reflection. He found himself writing a lot about mistakes, public performance anxiety, and the pressure to get a piece just right. Focusing in, Josh thought about a specific piece which helped him get over some performance anxiety, so he'll write about learning that piece and facing the fear.

Essay #4: Michael on surfing

We've already referenced Michael's essay a few times, but he'll be writing about his grandfather teaching him to surf and the lessons surfing has given him off the board and out of the waves.

You'll see us return to these students' ideas as we work through outlines.

Writing the Common App Essay

If your child spent their summer freewriting and then carefully selecting the right essay topic, you're now in a strong place to start writing—ideally at the end of July or early August. (Remember that if you are applying early action or early decision to schools your deadline will come at the start of November, whereas regular decision applications will generally have December and January deadlines.) We can't emphasize enough the importance of this organized pre-work, though—it's incredibly frustrating for a student to write an entire draft and then find that it's just "falling flat" or "doesn't sound like them" or "is cliché." Using the criteria we've already set out, though, you can avoid that scary feeling of having done a lot of work that you've got to shelve.

What 'type' of essay do you have to write? (list of narrative strategies)

It's important to remember that there are as many narrative strategies as there are television shows, books, movies, plays, and poems. We can't exhaustively discuss all of them, or even most, but we can give you a few "modules" to play with.

At 650 words, each of these will be best understood as a five-paragraph essay, so a basic structure stays the same, but the way things begin and end will not.

1. The Specific Experience Essay: This module is one of the most flexible and powerful types of essays. It begins with a scene, memory, or anecdote, and then tells us what that scene, memory, or anecdote continues to mean to the writer. It's a classic, and should not be underestimated. Michael's essay about learning to surf with his grandfather will use this structure, but so too will Anita's about taking a wilderness solo. Anita will use a slightly more subtle version of this, but both essays begin with a scene: "I was eight when my grandfather first took me to the

water” “The happiest two hours I have spent were on a boulder jutting into a stream in North Carolina...”

Resolving the Specific Experience Essay requires a student to point to some kind of realization garnered as a result of the experience. It doesn't have to be an enormous Eureka! or epiphany, and in fact, it can come later. Michael's reflection on the experience of learning to surf with his grandfather occurs over a decade after he first hit the waves. Anita's comes during an English class two years later when she first reads the poetry of John Keats and William Wordsworth and realizes these writers were engaging with exactly what she experienced during her solo in the wilderness. The trick Michael and Anita each pull off is spinning the experience forward so that it means something for the rest of their lives. Michael writes about how he understands meditative headspace as a result of standing on the board all those hours with his grandfather, and how his grandfather's legacy will always be with him. Anita goes small with her reflection: she talks about how she learned to see art, and artful experiences, in her everyday life, and in small, quiet moments. (This is especially good for Anita because it expands her away from just the hyper-intense mock trial competitor she might come across as.)

2. The Patterned/Iterative Essay: This module is a little more advanced. Let's take Josh's essay about piano playing. He might want to open with a scene of him playing piano on stage, but that's a little obvious. The essay he's going to write is actually about practice, and learning to stop making mistakes. So what if he started each paragraph with a different mini-moment of him playing piano and making a mistake? Paragraph 1: My first time erring on stage—I am six, and I'm playing Chopsticks. Then he'll introduce the theme of the essay. Paragraph #2: My second time messing up—I am thirteen, and... etc. Then the natural place to end it is the time he almost messes up but doesn't, which shows us how he's grown overtime.

3. The Circular Essay: In this essay, the writer begins with a scene or image or concept and then will circle back to that scene or image or concept before the end of the essay in order to make sense of the initial opening. This essay deploys suspense. Take Anita's essay, which might open: “I spent my happiest moments lost and alone in the wilderness. How did I get here? To understand that, you'll

have to understand X, Y, Z about me...” and which might close: “...that’s how I found myself, at sixteen, lost—but entirely at home in the wild.”

4. The Mini-Odyssey Essay: The last classic and powerful module is the good old problem-driven essay. In this type of essay, our hero (you, the writer) meets a challenge in the first paragraph and then the essay is devoted to showing us how it is solved. Let’s say Michael wanted to write not about learning to surf from his grandfather but about learning when his grandfather was diagnosed with terminal cancer. There’s a lot of narration that will be required for Michael to tell us about losing his grandfather—it’s too much to cram into the first paragraph. So Michael might distribute the narration chronologically, showing us first the bad news [the problem]—then zooming out to reflect; then showing us how he faced it [addressing the challenge], probably failing to adequately face it perfectly the first time, and then eventually facing it successfully [the solution].

Those are just a few more narrative possibilities for structuring your essay. Right now, we’ll focus on Ramya’s.

Outlining

Now, taking your chosen topic, it’s time to outline it. Outlining works great for some people as a pre-writing tactic, and we always recommend it. For others, it can be harder than simply getting down to writing. If you’re really struggling to outline and would rather just follow the pen to a first draft, that’s fine, but do yourself a favor and make outlining your second draft step. At some point, everyone needs an outline, but it’s your call when to do it. Let’s follow this through with Ramya’s essay on the Patriots. The model we’ll use for this essay is a five-paragraph, anecdote-driven essay.

By the way, this prompt helped Ramya settle on the Patriots—*Describe a place or environment where you are perfectly content. What do you do or experience there, and why is it meaningful to you?* Ramya’s going to write about the sports bar where she watches her team play every Sunday during football season.

1. Introduction: Anecdote/scene: Ramya has a fun advantage to her essay—it’s unexpected. The heart of it takes place in a sports bar, and she may seem, on paper, to the admissions committee, to be an unlikely diehard football fan. So we

begin... at the bar... and Ramya sets the scene: It had been a rough week at school—drama with my friend group, hard tests, orchestra practice, exhausting soccer drills—but I knew where I belonged on a Sunday. At Dee's Sports Bar in San Jose, with my dad, watching our team... She also tells us about Dee's itself, taking the chance to show the admissions committee that she has narrative skills in just noticing things: By the end of the football season, the staff knew what we wanted to sit... we were loyal to Dee's, just as we had to be loyal to the Patriots, even when they seemed to be letting us down. In telling this as a story, Ramya has given the admissions committee a human being to relate to from the jump.

2. Billboard/nutgraph/thesis paragraph: in the magazine world, they call the second paragraph in a piece the “billboard paragraph” because it broadcasts—loud as on a billboard—what the piece is about. Newspapers call the same thing a nutgraph, and academic papers would refer to your thesis statement. All these point to one thing: this is where you shout, HEY! THIS IS WHAT MY ESSAY IS ABOUT! This is where you meld the scene and characters of paragraph 1 with the thematic concerns you'll address for the rest of the essay. For Ramya, it goes something like this: Dee's is where I learned to be loyal—to my team, the Patriots, from across the country—but also to my father, to my friends, and to myself. Ramya's essay is going to focus on loyalty: a big theme, one that would sound terribly weak if she introduced it in the first line or even paragraph, but one that is surprising and interesting here because she's juxtaposed it against a unique setting and seemingly light fare—sports at a bar. (Ramya has, at some point, assured the admissions committee that she's not drinking in this bar!)

3. Body paragraph #1: In this paragraph, Ramya will tell us something more about loyalty, and why it matters. She'll add context. So she will zoom away from Dee's and tell us that throughout high school, she started noticing a lot of her friends getting caught up in social drama, becoming competitive with one another, fighting about romantic situations; set against all this, as well as bullying, depression, and other difficult parts of high school, Ramya's loyalty to the Patriots and Dee's served as a sanctuary—one of the things that kept her sane.

Now, it's crucial to note that this isn't enough for Ramya to write an essay about. “Here's something that is important/valuable/meaningful to me” is sometimes where students stop. Ramya needs to advance that—to tell us something that

shows maturity, shows an ability to reflect and introspect that will come in handy in college and adulthood...

4. Body paragraph #2: ...so she uses her next paragraph to make a bigger point: what other types of loyalty being at Dee's on a Sunday causes her to reflect on.

5. Conclusion: now, Ramya will spin the whole thing forward and point our eyes toward that 'lesson'—the thing that she can put in her pocket, which will serve as a kind of talisman throughout life.

Writing and revising: common errors

Most people don't outline. And even after outlining, many people fail to follow their outline. It's natural to want to stray here or there, towards or away from the initial plan, but below are a few **common errors** that people make when they either don't outline or ditch the guiding hand of their outline. As we go through some of these errors, we'll also make a list of a few **general tips and tricks** for managing some of the toughest parts of an essay, including time, scene, epiphany, change, character, and more.

Here's an excerpted version of how Ramya's essay began, at first: [Ramya's original drafts have been very slightly modified]

As a 5'1.75" Asian girl, not many people would expect me to spend every Sunday in a bar watching football....I was tired of streaming the games on my computer, and having it lag before every major play.

I want to thank Dee's Sports Bar for teaching me life lessons that I will carry with me for the rest of my life. Thank you for showing me the importance of loyalty, relationships, and laughter.

I have always been loyal to the Patriots....

It's not a bad start, but it brings us to **Common Error #1: beginning the essay by introducing oneself, instead of introducing the story, AKA, starting too broad.** Ramya begins by trying to tell us who she is in a big, introductory, throat-clearing way, instead of choosing a specific route into who she is. It's sweet that she's small, but

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there's a lot in here that we don't need: we don't need her height, nor do we need to know that she used to get the games in one particular way or another. We just need to know that she's at the bar.

She's only got 650 words. Which leads us to **Tip #1: Take refuge in a specific anecdote..** Many writers get stressed out, believing that they must convey their entire selves in an essay. This just isn't possible to do in the capsule of space that is the Common App personal statement. Those who try to do so often accomplish the opposite: an essay that's shapeless and meandering. If you instead use an individual story as a stand-in for something larger, or for something else, your essay becomes a kind of parable or lesson that educates your reader both about you and, hopefully, about a part of the world they've never previously considered.

Now, think about the first declarative sentence Ramya makes in that initial draft: "I have always been loyal to the Patriots." **Tip #2: Struggling to define your thesis statement? Look for the first declarative statement!** Ramya's essay can't be about her perpetual loyalty to the Patriots—that won't be enough. But the fact that her prose naturally settled on that as its first short, sharp sentence tells us that she's making a statement she probably believes in. Loyalty now becomes really important as a theme. **Common Error #2: Hiding the thesis statement or burying it too low.** Since we know that loyalty will have something to do with Ramya's thesis statement, we now know we want it to arrive at the end of the first paragraph or at the start of the first.

Here's how Ramya's essay began at the end of 3-4 rounds of edits and revisions:

Just before 5 pm on Sunday, October 13, 2013, I was sitting in a bar, holding on to a feeling of optimism that was fading fast. But wait: it's not what you think. I didn't turn to drink; I turned to the TV screen. The score was 27-23, and the Patriots had missed too many opportunities. With just over a minute left to play, my dad—the man responsible for bringing me, a 15-year-old, to a bar—dejectedly asked me if we should leave. I reminded him a true sports fan never gives up on her team, no matter the situation. And after a miracle of a drive finished with an unforgettable pass into the corner of the endzone by my idol, Tom Brady, a swell of elated cheering and high-fiving from the fans in the bar ensued regardless of whether we had previously known one another. Loyalty brought us all together.

Another **Common Error (#3!)** that Ramya made was: **Mixing up the conclusion's sentiment with the billboard paragraph.** Her second paragraph, in the original essay, read: "I want to thank Dee's Sports Bar for teaching me life lessons that I will carry with me for the rest of my life. Thank you for showing me the importance of loyalty, relationships, and laughter." That's a sentiment, but it's not a thesis. And that sentiment is fine—it may have a place at the end of the essay—but it doesn't belong in the second paragraph, because it doesn't guide our reading of the rest of the essay. It isn't strong and declarative yet.

This was the billboard paragraph Ramya reached after a few rounds of edits:

There are a few different kinds of loyalty. Loyalty to a team, to an establishment, to other people—even to oneself. Sitting in that bar over the last year, I feel like I've glimpsed them all.

A lot is working here! It's short, clear, and leads us to—**Tip #3: define your terms.** Ramya wants to talk about an abstract concept—loyalty. Many young writers wish to reflect on things like charity, service, leadership, loyalty, friendship, kindness, morality, etc—these are big topics. But Ramya isn't just talking about loyalty, a word which could mean many different things to many different people. She's defined loyalty for the purposes of this essay, which means now we are playing in her house.

As Ramya's original first draft moved on, it stumbled into a very **Common Error #4: the curious case of the missing lesson.** Initially, Ramya's penultimate paragraph offered a kind of ode to Dee's instead of showing the admissions committee that she has a bigger Life Takeaway from her time spent supporting her team—a problem we could see would happen as soon as we noticed the sentiment of "Thanks Dee's" occupying the place that should have been reserved for a billboard paragraph. Returning to the outline, or making the outline partway through, would remedy that.

Tip #4: Try a reverse outline. Once your child has written the first draft of their essay, they should print it out and write what the function of each paragraph is in the margin. If they can't answer the question "what is the goal of this paragraph?" or "what do I want the readers to garner from this paragraph?" then it's probably missing a **topic sentence.**

Everything we're talking about here—writing, noticing mistakes, correcting them—will take at least three and as many as five or six drafts to get right. So, **Tip #5: Don't treat early drafts like anything close to final.** That means getting comfortable with simply putting ideas to paper, and with cutting entire paragraphs or "points" within the essay. Your child has probably never written anything like the personal statement before, and the more revisions, the better—otherwise, your child risks submitting a weaker version of the essay.

Tip #6: Read drafts aloud. The purpose of reading aloud is to prevent **Common Error #5: tonal errors—sounding too formal or too glib/casual.** Ramya never suffered from either of these problems; she sounded like herself even in early drafts. But many students feel that they either have to sound formal to the point of stuffiness ("On a Sunday afternoon, my father would pick me up from my room and take me down to the kitchen, whereupon we would adjourn to Dee's Sports bar...") or "authentically young" to the point of disrespecting the reader ("On Sundays my dad's like, let's go to Dee's Sports Bar, and I go okay so I come on down and we get going...") It can be easy to fall into one of these traps, and to write in a voice that isn't authentic **Tip #7: The right essay-voice is the most polished version of your speaking-voice.** You shouldn't sound like you swallowed a Thesaurus, but you should sound a little more formal than your text messages to your friends would.

Full-length personal statement example

Here's what Ramya's essay looked like, in the end:

Just before 5 pm on Sunday, October 13, 2013, I was sitting in a bar, holding on to a feeling of optimism that was fading fast. But wait—it's not what you think. I didn't turn to drink—I turned to the TV screen. The score was 27-23, and the Patriots had missed too many opportunities. With just over a minute left to play, my dad—the man responsible for bringing me, a 15-year-old, to a bar—dejectedly asked me if we should leave. I reminded him a true sports fan never gives up on her team, no matter the situation. And after a miracle of a drive finished with an unforgettable pass into the corner of the endzone by my idol, Tom Brady, a swell of elated cheering and high-fiving from the fans in the bar ensued regardless of whether we had previously known one another. Loyalty brought us all together.

There are a few different kinds of loyalty. Loyalty to a team, to an establishment, to other people—even to oneself. Sitting in that bar over the last year, I feel like I've glimpsed them all. As a Boston-born girl, my loyalty to the Patriots seems natural—even if it's not so common for a teenage Indian-American-Californian girl to be as much of a sports junkie as I am. But I've seen that loyalty tested plenty of times. I'm completely invested in the Pats; I've been known to be giddy when they win, and tearful when they lose. However, finding a true home to watch Patriots games in California isn't easy. So I owe Dee's Sports Bar a surprising amount. By the end of the season, the staff knew what we wanted to eat, and where we wanted to sit, so the sports bar felt like a second home.

My dad and I have a typical father-daughter relationship; I get mad when he doesn't let me go out, he gets mad when I neglect responsibility. But in the year since we began staking out the bar, we've gotten so much closer. On the rides to and from, we talked about everything from school to politics to pop culture. And we talk about sports as equals. My best friend once told me that neither she nor her dad were willing to make the extra effort to find common ground. And I realized how lucky I was: sports offers my dad and me an inexhaustible topic that we can always turn to.

The bar also helped me figure out still another kind of loyalty—to myself. Junior year was an emotional year, full of difficult academics and the inevitable social drama that comes with high school. The bar showed me that I needed to look forward to something comfortable—a place with no drama, no obligations, and a common goal... or at least, a common desperate desire for victory. At the bar, nobody cared what I got on my last math test or which boy was asking my friend to prom. All that matters is the game. This realization isn't limited to just sports; I figured out that I need a place to be completely myself—with my team and my dad. This included deciding that I only wanted to stay friends with people who make a positive impact on my life. These were such simple revelations, yet they made all the difference.

I have always been loyal to the New England Patriots. From my toddler days, as I sat mesmerized in front of the screen to today, as I analyze every statistic that I can get my hands on, I love every aspect of the team. But all of those trips to the

sports bar taught me important lessons that apply beyond football. And for that, I am grateful.

Lesson 6

Strategies to Impress With the Common App Activities Section

Sharing accomplishments in a way that shines

In addition to the Common App Essay and school-specific supplemental essays, your child will have to complete the Common App Activities section.

Whereas the personal statement will show college admissions committees who your child *is*, the Common App Activities section will allow colleges to understand what your child has *done* and is doing outside of the classroom, offering one of the best opportunities to stand out among other applicants.

Without college essays and extracurricular activities lists, colleges would be limited to grades, class rank, and ACT and SAT scores to make their admissions decisions. Given that so many students with strong numbers apply to college each year, it's important for your child to use the Activities section to develop an application theme, that is, their "it factor" and specialties.

Before we get into writing tips and sample extracurricular descriptions, let's go over a few Activities section basics:

What qualifies as an activity?

According to Common App, "activities may include arts, athletics, clubs, employment, personal commitments, and other pursuits." In other words, pretty much anything pursued outside the classroom qualifies as an activity.

How many activities can be listed?

Your child may list up to 10 activities.

What are the word or character limits for each activity?

Common App sets the following limits for each activity:

Position/Leadership description and organization name, if applicable: 50 characters

Activity description, including what your child accomplished and any recognition they received, etc.: 150 characters

As you can see, there is very limited space offered for each activity, so we'll be discussing how to maximize the impact of each entry below.

What other information does Common App collect for each activity?

Common App requests the following information for each activity:

- Activity type (e.g., Art, Athletics, Community Service, Debate/Speech, Foreign Language, Research, Social Justice, Work)
- Participation grade levels (9, 10, 11, 12, Post-graduate)
- Timing of participation (During school year, During school break, All year)
- Hours spent per week
- Weeks spent per year
- Whether or not your child intends to participate in a similar activity in college (Yes/No)

Writing Strategies

Now that we've covered the basics, let's discuss some proven approaches to completing a strong Activities section:

1. Include role *and* organization name in the top box

The first three fields for each Activity on Common App look like this:

Activity 1

Activity type*

Choose an option ▼

Position/Leadership description and organization name, if applicable*

Please describe this activity, including what you accomplished and any recognition you received, etc.
(Max characters: 150)*

After selecting an Activity type from the drop-down menu, your child should describe their position *and* organization name in the corresponding box. That way, your child can use the full 150-character limit for the activity description box.

For example, rather than writing “Student Council” or “President”, your child should write “President, Student Council”.

2. Do not repeat words from the position description box in the activity description box

Continuing with the student council president example: Instead of writing, “As president of the student body, I was responsible for...”, your child should write, “Responsible for meeting agendas, liaising with administration, and implementing school initiatives, such as free textbooks for low-income families.”

3. Focus on quantifiable and significant impact

Many applicants undersell their achievements because they don’t get specific enough about their contributions. For example, rather than write something like, “Organized food can drive for local families”, your child should write, “Collected over 10,000 cans and provided Thanksgiving meals for 500 families in greater Cleveland.” With details like that, your child’s impact will be unquestionable to admissions committees.

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4. List tasks and avoid complete sentences to make room for more detail

Colleges understand that your child does not have enough space to provide in-depth descriptions of each activity. Therefore, rather than write, for example, “At the hospital, I transported patients with physical disabilities on wheelchairs...”, your child should write, “Transported patients on wheelchairs, provided meals and blankets, assembled gift baskets, and attended grand rounds.”

5. Describe current activities using present tense

For instance, rather than, “I tutored seventh graders in science”, your child should write, “I help seventh graders master challenging science concepts.”

Advanced Strategies

1. List activities in order of importance and impressiveness

Activities listed earlier will be better remembered by admissions committees, so your child should lead with their most impactful and meaningful ones. Moreover, by capturing admissions committees’ positive attention early on, they will review the rest of your child’s Activities list more favorably.

2. Make activities sound as impressive as possible

Dr. Cal Newport first popularized the concept of the failed simulation effect, defined as follows: “Accomplishments that are hard to explain can be much more impressive than accomplishments that are simply hard to do.” Therefore, within each activity’s description, your child should describe accomplishments that are hardest to explain. For example, if your child blogs about mental health and had an opportunity to meet with a local city councilperson to develop a mental health awareness initiative in your county, they should mention that. It’s important to note, however, that your child should never fabricate or exaggerate achievements and activities for the sake of impressiveness.

3. Chunk related activities together to develop a theme

College admissions committees look not only for activities in which your child has participated for a number of years, but also for groups of related activities. For example, let's compare the following students' activities:

Student 1

- High school basketball team captain
- Model United Nations award winner
- Piano club president
- Elementary school English tutor

Student 2

- High school basketball team member
- Youth basketball team coach
- Organized local basketball tournament for kids with special needs
- Interned with local professional basketball team's analytics department

Clearly, Student 2 passes the failed simulation effect test while also demonstrating significant impact and achievement through a single area—basketball. On the other hand, Student 1 lists unrelated activities that make them seem well-rounded, but nothing particularly stands out. Collectively, Student 2's activities will be more memorable and seem more impressive than Student 1's.

Activities Section Example

Intern, Google Virtual Reality (VR)

Coded VR environments for various software prototypes, some of which were featured at the 2017 Consumer Electronics Show.

Founder and President, Code for Community

Organize coding camps for middle and high schoolers from inner-city Chicago whose schools do not offer computer science classes.

President, Coding Club

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Major projects include developing software for school to track student grades, assignments, and parent communications.

Assistant Instructor, Tae Kwon Do

Train 5- to 6-year-old martial arts students to develop proper technique and instill confidence.

Tae Kwon Do

Achieved black belt at age 16 and currently training for state tournament.

Writing Peer Counselor, The Hamilton School

Supported high school students with all forms of writing, including in-class assignments, AP exam essays, and school newspaper articles.

Math Tutor, The Hamilton School

Support struggling middle and high school students with Algebra 1 and 2, Geometry, Precalculus, and Calculus.

President, Cru Club

Host monthly speaking events with athletes, principals, etc. for 80 students from all over Chicago to help them discover aspects of their purpose.

Customer Service Representative, Elegant Cleaners

Greeted customers, processed orders and payments, and returned clothing items.

Waitress, Blue Ribbon Diner

Took customer orders, served food and drinks, and processed payments

Lesson 7

Tackling Supplemental College Application Essays to Demonstrate “Fit”

How to impress admissions committees through any school-specific essay prompt

Now that your child has finished the most challenging part of the college application process, the Common App Essay (a.k.a. personal statement), it's time to address the various supplemental (a.k.a. secondary) essays that schools like Harvard, Princeton, Yale, Stanford, and many others will ask them to fill out. Whereas some universities will ask your child to complete one additional essay, other schools, will ask them to complete multiple essays. In addition, the essay lengths will vary from school to school and from prompt to prompt.

Some students think they should treat their personal statement as the main “essay question” on the test, whereas they consider the supplemental essays as “short answer” questions. While it's true that your child's personal statement almost always allows you the most space to share an aspect of who they are, it's important to treat supplementaries with the same rigor.

The admissions committees use your child's secondary essays to augment the story they have assembled from your child's Common App Essay and letters of recommendation. They are looking for more details that confirm what they've heard about your child, expand on that, and neither contradict nor repeat what they've already learned from your child's personal statement.

Let's replace the “essay question” and “short answer” analogy we hear from students a lot with an interview analogy. The Common App Essay is the initial answer you get to give the interviewer when they say, “Tell me about yourself.” You deliver that with

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excellent posture and careful word choice. Now, as the interview continues, and the questions become things like, “Why would you like to attend our school?” and “What’s your favorite snack?” and “Can you elaborate more on your favorite extracurricular?” You don’t want to kick off your shoes, slouch in your chair, and develop a sudden drawl as you respond to your interviewer.

Realizing that the supplemental essays, which range in length from 25 characters to 650 or more words, are, well, still essays, and still require outlining, planning, and editing, some students can freeze up. Your child has just completed a mammoth task of squeezing their story into the personal statement. The good news is that the skills and rhythms they developed while writing the personal statement remain applicable for your supplemental essays. To better prepare for supplemental essays, we highly recommend working through our step-by-step guide to writing the Common App Essay first.

From outlining to writing

In preparing to write the Common App Essay, your child probably left some material “on the cutting room floor,” so to speak—meaning they probably thought about topics or experiences which were meaningful but not ideal for the personal statement. Now is the chance to make use of that excess!

The exercises and prompts we used to prepare for the Common App personal statement can serve as excellent grounding for addressing the many types of questions that come up in the supplemental essays.

The difference is how your child will make use of them in the supplemental essays that are generally shorter.

Here’s a general strategy for approaching essays of varying lengths. We’ll shortly tackle examples of the essays themselves by subject matter:

The 650-word essay

In this essay, a college may simply give you a chance to write another Common App-style personal statement.

Here's an example prompt:

Princeton University: In addition to the essay you have written for the Common Application, please write an essay of about 500 words (no more than 650 words and no fewer than 250 words). Using one of the themes below as a starting point, write about a person, event, or experience that helped you define one of your values or in some way changed how you approach the world. Please do not repeat, in full or in part, the essay you wrote for the Common Application.

- Tell us about a person who has influenced you in a significant way.
- “One of the great challenges of our time is that the disparities we face today have more complex causes and point less straightforwardly to solutions.” Omar Wasow, assistant professor of politics, Princeton University. This quote is taken from Professor Wasow’s January 2014 speech at the Martin Luther King Day celebration at Princeton University.
- “Culture is what presents us with the kinds of valuable things that can fill a life. And insofar as we can recognize the value in those things and make them part of our lives, our lives are meaningful.” Gideon Rosen, Stuart Professor of Philosophy and director of the Behrman Undergraduate Society of Fellows, Princeton University.
- Using a favorite quotation from an essay or book you have read in the last three years as a starting point, tell us about an event or experience that helped you define one of your values or changed how you approach the world. Please write the quotation, title and author at the beginning of your essay.

Strategies for the 650-word essay

It’s the personal statement 2.0—so rinse, lather, repeat! Your child should go through the materials from [the pre-writing phase of the Common App Essay](#), and the list of topics they made originally, and choose the one that almost made the cut for the personal statement but didn’t. Then, they should outline it with the same rigor and attention that they gave the Common App!

This means using the traditional five-paragraph essay tools: an intro paragraph with a lede or hook of some sort, a billboard paragraph, two body paragraphs, and a conclusion. Like the personal statement, using an anecdote or specific story as the framework is an appropriate strategy.

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The 500-word essay

Example

Rice University: The quality of Rice's academic life and the Residential College System are heavily influenced by the unique life experiences and cultural traditions each student brings. What personal perspective do you feel that you will contribute to life at Rice? (500)

Strategies for this essay

With just 500 words to work with here, we might want to think slightly smaller or more contained than a five-paragraph essay revolving around an anecdote or personal experience. Instead, let's think in terms of the following units:

- A topic or thesis statement that unites the question with a personal experience.
- Some “evidence,” drawing on personal history, that supports the thesis statement.
- The one-line zinger that ensures the committee knows your child read the question and is answering it.

Here they are again, with examples based on our student Ramya, whom you met during the personal-statement-writing process:

A topic or thesis statement that unites the question with your child's personal experience

Ramya came up with a number of things that make her uniquely “her,” and which her friends, family, teachers, and counselors would all recognize as her. She's planning on studying medicine but is a rabid sports fan, loves football and soccer, and is also a loyal friend. Ramya is also Indian-American and comes from a small town in California where being Asian does not actually make her a minority. So while some students might choose to write about race or identity or other things we ‘traditionally’ think of when thinking of ‘diversity,’ Ramya's mind doesn't go there. Instead, she thinks about... Harry Potter. Hold that thought.

Here's what she thought about when asked to consider what made her different:

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I grew up in a community full of ambitious people, all of whom were told to be leaders. What makes me unlike them? I'm not the one who stands up at the front of the room to try to run things. I'm the one who makes them run, behind the scenes. In fact, I'm the dependable one, the loyal one...

Ramya's personal experience has shown her that this makes her different.

So, what about Harry Potter? Here's how Ramya articulates this to her readers:

I was raised on J.K. Rowling's Harry Potter series. As a kid, I remember friends choosing which house they thought they'd be sorted into: brave in Gryffindor, smart in Ravenclaw, ambitious in Slytherin, and... everyone else in Hufflepuff. Rowling says Hufflepuffs are the 'loyal and true.' But when friends and I talked about landing up as a badger, it seemed like we were doomed.

Some “evidence,” drawing on personal history, that supports the thesis statement

Now, just as we used anecdotes and set scenes for readers while writing the personal statement, we want to do something similar here. But we don't have time for Ramya to walk us through the room where her heart pounded as she revealed herself to be a Hufflepuff. We have to move more efficiently this time, without sacrificing specificity.

One way to do that is by writing in a list, as Ramya did here:

Strangely, though, as we got older, it was exactly my Hufflepuff qualities that my friend group seemed to depend on the most. 'You might belong in Hufflepuff,' the Sorting Hat sings, 'where they are just and loyal.' Hufflepuffs are 'patient,' 'true,' and 'unafraid of toil.' It's not a thrilling description! No bravery, no promises of ruling the world here. But those words all seemed to describe me.

During my junior year, I found my friends turning to me after the loss of a classmate. We needed people to organize an assembly, a memorial, and a charity in the classmate's name. My school was going through a difficult time, and everyone was trying to contribute in their way. But we were all young and new to grief, which meant we didn't always know how to get things right. Some people were quick to speak or write about the classmate, believing that someone had to

take a 'leadership' role. Others felt uncomfortable and tried to move on past it entirely. I was quiet, as I often am, but when I saw how many ways people were trying to respond, I realized we didn't need another 'leader' to step in. We needed loyal followers and patient workers to follow through on the many initiatives that people were trying to start in the wake of this classmate's passing.

The one-line zinger that ensures the committee knows you read the question and are answering it

Because many essays are like opening a door to a larger conversation, it can be easy to wander through the door and begin pacing around the interesting room you have discovered on the other side. But don't forget your manners! At some point you have to make sure you acknowledge that a specific door was opened. Leaving that metaphor before we wring it dry: in plain terms, remember that, unlike in the case of the personal statement, the supplemental essays often ask a specific question that your child must answer. It's important that the concluding statement or one of the last few lines gets into that.

This Rice essay has Ramya musing on what makes her 'different' (her Hufflepuff-ness) and has sent her into anecdotal territory, remembering her classmate's loss. But she has to bring it home, and answer that question specifically, not just introduce the committee to something quirky and distinctive about her.

Here's how she does it:

If there's one thing I, and the generation of kids who grew up on Rowling's series, learned from those books, it's that you need all types of people, represented by all four houses. My personality, as a loyal, heads-down, sometimes quiet, Hufflepuff, often made me think of myself as 'boring' when I was younger. But for the past year, I've seen how it can be a strength, not just to me, but also to the community I belong to.

I am applying to Rice early because it feels like a strong community. From the residential college system to the tight-knit campus, I can see myself giving my best Hufflepuff qualities to my classmates and peers during intramural sports

tournaments, late-night study sessions, and more—in the face of both everyday trials and larger, scarier moments in life.

Ramya has done a double-whammy here, telling us not only about what the community gets from her unique qualities, but also slipping in an answer to the ‘Why Rice’ question that she’ll soon have one more chance to respond to in full.

The 150-250-word or other very short essay

Here’s an example, from USC:

Describe how you plan to pursue your academic interests at USC. Please feel free to address your first- and second-choice major selections. (250 word limit)

Strategies for the short essay

With a short amount of space to work with, we’re going to need extremely taut and clear sentences. This essay doesn’t need the fancy flourish of anecdotal hooks or ledes; in fact, you can’t back into this essay through narrative. Clarity and direct responses to this kind of question will help your child win the game.

The components of a successful answer to an essay of this length:

- A topic sentence that explicitly answers the question that has been asked
- Evidence supporting the conclusion (in this case, that neuroscience is the right major for Josh)
- A dash of introspection to finish the day

Here’s what Josh, our pianist and soccer player, wrote:

I hope to double-major in neuroscience and cinema and media studies at USC. Though I eventually may want to attend medical school, I want to use the liberal arts curriculum at USC to explore multiple disciplines as an undergraduate. The combination of neuroscience and cinema studies might seem surprising to some, but together the two majors form a tribute to the reason I love science at all. My elementary and middle schools did not have strong STEM programs, and so my teachers, seeing a student enthusiastic about science, used to put on science

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documentaries when I had finished the homework. Watching Stephen Hawking, Oliver Sacks, and Neil deGrasse Tyson, I discovered things that could not have reached me from just the textbook. My hope is to use half my time at USC to take courses that prepare me for a career in neuroscience while spending the other half in classrooms that teach documentary filmmaking and production. I hope to intern at least one summer at a production company specializing in science documentaries, and to do a senior project that might eventually see screen time, either online or on the silver screen. Whether or not I go on to make films as a career, I know that learning how to communicate complicated ideas to the public will serve me well as a scientist.

Josh's essay is successful for a number of reasons, but particularly because it not only answers the question (how will you pursue your interests) through mention of particular types of classes he'd like to take, summer internships he'd like to pursue, and his eventual goals with both majors. It's also excellent because it's tailored to USC, the asking school; like Ramya's Rice essay, it serves as an additional mini essay proving Josh's knowledge of and passion about the school.

Types of secondary and supplemental essays

While your child may face a number of different types of questions when tackling secondary and supplemental essays, there are certain prompts and certain "genres" of prompts that come up again and again. It's a good idea to be aware of the general types of secondary essays that can come up.

You'll notice that many of these secondaries touch on things that you scribbled about way back during your pre-writing phase, while others may ask your child to do some thinking about the qualities of the specific college to which they are applying.

We've broken down the wild sea of supplemental essays into a few particular types of questions and come up with some strategies for your child to approach the next phase of your application with!

The 'why us' essay

Some colleges will ask your child to explain why they'd like to attend X university.

Here are some example “why us” prompts:

- **Barnard College:** What factors influenced your decision to apply to Barnard College and why do you think the College would be a good match for you? (100-250 words)
- **Davidson College:** Why Davidson? (250-300 Suggested Word Limit)
- **Dartmouth College:** 100 words or less: While arguing a Dartmouth-related case before the U.S. Supreme Court in 1818, Daniel Webster, Class of 1801, uttered this memorable line: "It is, Sir...a small college. And yet, there are those who love it!" As you seek admission to the Class of 2022, what aspects of the College's program, community, or campus environment attract your interest?

Strategies for addressing the ‘why us’ essay

Work backward. Think about what your big dream is—what or who you hope to become—and identify a few specific things about each college you're applying to, asking yourself how each one of those is going to help you get there.

Have a ‘mini-thesis’ for each school rather than having a general list of qualities the school meets for you. Anita, our humanities-oriented student, writes that she's interested in studying history, and includes a tidbit in her “Why Yale” essay from the campus tour she was able to take, about how Yale's architects were so obsessed with the past that they built the campus to look even older than it is. This jives with her own interest and the fact that Yale has one of the best history departments in the country.

Go beyond the website, and be specific. Don't restate the “About Barnard” section of the Barnard brochure to the admissions committee—they already know why they offer you a great opportunity. Talk about your experiences with the college you're applying to—did you visit and hear something from a tour guide, admissions officer, student, or professor? If you couldn't visit, did you do some online research that got you in touch with some of the Big Themes a tour guide or info session would hit? Is there a particular class you've heard of that's legendary on campus? A tradition at the school? An alumna/alumnus of the college whose work has inspired you?

Here's an example of a great 'why us' essay, responding to Yale's prompt: What is it about Yale that has led you to apply? (125 words or less). Our mock trial champion from our Common App personal Essay guide, Anita, was admitted to Yale.

I hope to study history or English, and Yale's departments in both are some of the best in the world. I am drawn to the interdisciplinary humanities offerings, including the Directed Studies program and the Humanities major. A writer, I also hope to work on the Yale Daily News or the Globalist. But it isn't just the caliber of academics that draws me to Yale. It's also the sense that the campus itself is comprised of history and knowledge. From Sterling Memorial Library, literally constructed as a cathedral to knowledge, to the buildings the architects poured acid on to make them look older, I felt a sense of almost ancient respect for intellect when I visited.

Anita's essay is extremely specific, citing history, English, a freshman academic program, a particular major, two campus publications she wants to write for, and two facts she learned on her campus tour (which you could also get from watching a number of YouTube videos or speaking with local alumni or meeting admissions officers at a local college fair, if you're not able to visit schools). But it's also successful because it has a thesis that conveys a dual passion: a personal passion for her own academic interests, and a passion for the school. She converges her personal plans with the spirit of Yale, and that shows the admissions officers that she's a natural fit.

Tell us more about an extracurricular activity

Some colleges will simply ask for your child to elaborate further on an extracurricular activity or class they've already mentioned on the Common App Activities List. This is the only time your child should elaborate further on something already in their application.

Here's an example of such a prompt:

Please briefly elaborate on one of your extracurricular activities or work experiences that was particularly meaningful to you. (About 150 words)

Strategies for addressing the extracurricular essay

Choose an activity that means something to you, or that could benefit from being livened up by your prose. Anita our mock trial champion, chose to write about a wilderness solo. But now would be a good time for her to talk about mock trial—the thing the admissions committee will already know her for, but which now she can add some humanity to, without making it the only thing that defines her.

Don't write about the same thing you've written your Common App Essay on! Josh, who chose piano for his personal statement, will need to pick something else.

Here's another of Anita's essays, this one about her mock trial activities. Remember that mock trial is one of Anita's most obviously impressive activities. She's nationally competitive, and it will come up in her counselor and teacher recommendations and her national wins will show up on her resumé and lists of awards. But she hasn't written about it yet. Her job is not to summarize her wins—her recommenders and CV will do that for her—but to tell the admissions committee something they can't get from other portions of her application.

I spend several Saturdays a semester in front of a room full of people, acting out a story. It is one of the greatest adrenaline rushes I can think of. My role: I am an attorney, for a few hours. My motivation: simple. To win the case.

I'm not in the drama club. I've never been on a proper stage. I almost threw up as an eighth-grader at theater camp when I had to improvise a scene. And yet, I thrive as a member of the mock trial team. That's because when my job is to make sense of a series of arguments, to cross-examine my way to the heart of the trial, and to articulate a clear and powerful closing statement, I am inhabiting my best self. I am Atticus Finch and Clarence Darrow, and, most importantly, me.

Design a class/a major

Some colleges, especially those with a liberal arts foundation, will ask your child to come up with a seminar or even reimagine an entire department. Here are some example prompts:

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The University of Chicago: Due to a series of clerical errors, there is exactly one typo (an extra letter, a removed letter, or an altered letter) in the name of every department at the University of Chicago. Oops! Describe your new intended major. Why are you interested in it and what courses or areas of focus within it might you want to explore? Potential options include Commuter Science, Bromance Languages and Literatures, Pundamentals: Issues and Texts, Ant History... a full list of unmodified majors ready for your editor's eye is available here: collegeadmissions.uchicago.edu/majors - Inspired by Josh Kaufman, Class of 2018

Boston College: Boston College strives to provide an undergraduate learning experience emphasizing the liberal arts, quality teaching, personal formation, and engagement of critical issues. If you had the opportunity to create your own college course, what enduring question or contemporary problem would you address and why?

Strategies for addressing the design a class essay

This should be tons of fun—a way of getting to hear your child geek out and be creative; it's a chance for your child to show excitement about the chance to get a broad and varied education. The important thing here is to convey excitement for the reason the college is asking your child to do this at all: they are going to get a chance to study somewhere where intellectual curiosity is valued.

Here's Ramya's essay in answer to Emory's prompt:

Emory University: If you could create an academic course that is in the Emory University spirit of collaboration, creativity, entrepreneurship and inquiry, what would it be? What impact would the course have on you and your classmates' educational experience? (500)

Why do I love chocolate while my brother gags at the scent of it? Why are some people more attracted to Italian food than Mexican food? Why do we like some foods during the summer, and others during the fall? Can we predict what people

might find enjoyable based on their background and attitudes? As an avid foodie, I have always wondered what it is that attracts each person to different tastes.

These are a few of the questions we would answer in my Freshman Seminar class on “Food for Thought.”

We would purchase, cook, and taste foods from all around the world and observe the neurological effects that each has. While there is common knowledge of the basic proteins, carbohydrates, and fats, along with how a good balance should be struck in order to maintain a healthy lifestyle, this new class would focus on the subtle differences in types of signals emitted by the brain when different foods are consumed. Students would be exposed to the theory and practice of neuroimaging techniques such as fMRI and PET scans. We would identify neurotransmitters emitted as a result of the food ingested and study if different parts of the brain “light up” in response to different foods.

Along with creating a brain-food map, students would learn how to use statistically sound methods to study how variables such as a subject’s ethnic background, age, gender, and social attitudes such as open mindedness, correlate with the subject’s likes and dislikes.

This class will also address cultural elements of food. When eating foods from around the world, in order to fully appreciate the dish as a whole, it is important to understand the context surrounding what lands on our plates. We would read short stories or passages and watch excerpts of popular film focused on food from the countries whose cuisine we are testing. Cooking and tasting food together are great ways to bring people together, as seen in many movies such as Ratatouille and The Hundred-Foot Journey.

Not only would this class be informative, but it would also be an engaging, hands-on experience, and would provide freshmen with two valuable experiences during their first year at college—forming community and rethinking their fundamental approaches to academics by introducing them to interdisciplinary thought. “Food for Thought” would expose freshmen to an integrated approach to science while providing a fun environment for freshmen to get to know each other. At the end of the class, all students would have a better understanding of

neuroscience as well as an appreciation for different cultures and their unique foods.

Sign us up for Ramya's class! This is such a vibrant essay for a number of reasons. She's truly thrown herself into imagining an interdisciplinary topic that converges a fun, light part of her personality—food—with something already on her application—her interest in medicine and neuroscience. She's also made a few expert moves here, whether consciously or not. By pointing to the “valuable experiences” students need freshman year, she has indicated to the admissions committee that she understands that being a part of Emory involves both community and academics. That's the kind of person you want on your campus!

Why this major?

Some schools may ask your child to apply to a specific professional school or declare a major. Others may ask you to indicate an initial preference. Still others may expect no prior thought about majors:

Cornell University: Why are you drawn to studying the major you have selected? Please discuss how your interests and related experiences have influenced your choice. Specifically, how will an education from the College of Agriculture and Life Sciences (CALS) and Cornell University help you achieve your academic goals? (Please limit your response to 650 words.)

Brown University: Why are you drawn to the area(s) of study you indicated earlier in this application? If you are "undecided" or not sure which Brown concentrations match your interests, consider describing more generally the academic topics or modes of thought that engage you currently. (150 word limit)

USC: Describe how you plan to pursue your academic interests at USC. Please feel free to address your first- and second-choice major selections. (250 word limit)

Strategies for the ‘Why this major’ essay

This is one essay hiding two in it—it's a 'why us?' essay combined with an essay that wants your child to state where they see themselves in 5-10 years.

First, apply the same strategies you did for the 'why us' essay

(specifics!)—go to the website of the undergraduate program or major you're applying to/indicating interest in, and look at student or alumni profiles. Is there anyone who makes you say, "yeah, I'd love to do that"? Write about them. Is there a summer program, a particular class, an internship, or anything else associated with this program that attracts you?

Second, talk about where you want to be in 5-10 years. Imagine your dream job and tell the admissions committee how this particular program or major might help you reach it. This is a time when you can and should be specific—because you're not committing to the story you're writing down. You're just demonstrating that you've thought about it and have a passion or vocation pulling you in one direction or another.

We've shown you one example of a response to USC's question above. Here's another example, this one in response to Brown's prompt, from our student Josh, who isn't sure what he wants to study. But he's generally interested in international affairs and global political issues.

I am interested in studying International Relations or East Asian Studies. My mother is Chinese and my father is American. When they met, their two countries could not have been more distant. But today, China and America have to increasingly understand one another, economically, politically, and culturally. I am able to stand at the crossroads of these two countries, and I hope to use my time at Brown to learn Mandarin and to study abroad in China. I am also excited about the East Asian Studies requirement to engage with countries beyond China; learning about migratory patterns and cultural conversations in the region and studying Korea and Japan will help me crystallize my sense of the region.

Diversity-in-community essay

An essay that asks your child what they bring to the college community can seem like it's asking them to explain the ways in which they bring "diversity" to the community. They *could* answer in terms of identity—gender, racial, ethnic, socioeconomic, or

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otherwise—but you don't *have* to. Really, essays like this are asking for your child to identify one way in which they're different, and the way you make that difference a boon to others. Check out these prompts:

Rice University: The quality of Rice's academic life and the Residential College System are heavily influenced by the unique life experiences and cultural traditions each student brings. What personal perspective do you feel that you will contribute to life at Rice? (500)

Duke University: Optional essay: Duke University seeks a talented, engaged student body that embodies the wide range of human experience; we believe that the diversity of our students makes our community stronger. If you'd like to share a perspective you bring or experiences you've had to help us understand you better—perhaps related to a community you belong to or your family or cultural background—we encourage you to do so. Real people are reading your application, and we want to do our best to understand and appreciate the real people applying to Duke. (250 word limit)

Strategies for the diversity-in-community essay

Your child should go back to their pre-written prompts and think about what you noticed made you different, and unlike your peers. You're often looking for something intangible to others but tangible to you. Think about what you wrote about your parents or siblings, your hometown or community.

We've given you Ramya's response to this above, but here's another essay, from Michael responding to the Duke prompt, who wrote about surfing with his grandfather for the personal statement. Though Michael has included his grandfather in his application already, he takes a different angle on him for this optional essay so it does not feel redundant. Especially because this is a non-required answer, that repetition is fine.

I was born and raised in a small town in southern California and attended a big public high school. Here, everyone is racially mixed-up. Black, Asian, Hapa, Hispanic, and other combinations mingle in our loud school hallways. I never had much of a reason to think about my ethnic heritage until recently. My maternal

grandfather is Hawaiian, and he married a 'haole,' or a white person. My paternal grandparents are white Californians. I look almost entirely white, and I get to move through the world feeling like any old white guy. But when my grandfather got sick and eventually passed away at the end of high school, I became interested in that part of my background.

I learned about the state's history and the colonial presence that white people had. I also learned how many people in Hawaii now serve in the Armed Forces. This is a complicated history, and one I am interested in exploring more in college. Though I don't know if I will ever live in Hawaii long-term, I want to study history or anthropology to write about this part of American history, which I never knew about growing up. I think this cultural background could bring something unique to the Duke community. I also think it can contribute to conversations about social justice, which are big in my high school, but which entirely white people sometimes struggle to contribute to. My sense of containing multiple racial identities now will shape me and the school I attend.

Quick hits

Some universities ask for your child's "short takes" on a number of things, limiting responses to 35 words or so. Here are some example prompts:

Yale University: Yale's residential colleges regularly host intimate conversations with guests representing a wide range of experiences and accomplishments. What person, past or present, would you invite to speak? What question would you ask?

Princeton University:

- Two adjectives your friends would use to describe you:
- Your favorite word:

USC:

- What is your favorite snack?
- What TV show will you binge watch next?

Strategies for ‘quick hits’

Your child should be authentic and original. They might even have someone else read the short questions aloud in a rapid fire fashion, and answer instinctively. This is a chance for your child to sound like the person their friends and family know and love.

Lesson 8

How to Ace College Interviews

The dos and don'ts your child needs to know to stand out during college admissions interviews

Now that your child has submitted their college application materials, they're probably anxious to hear back from their top-choice schools. However, it's wrong to believe that they can now kick their feet up and cruise through the rest of senior year.

Many universities—mostly private schools—ask alumni or other admissions staff to meet with college applicants on behalf of the admissions committee. Their goal is either: 1) to evaluate your child for admission, 2) to offer your child an opportunity to learn more about their school, or 3) both.

Although this meeting is an important part of the application process and may be nerve-racking for your child, here are several considerations and related tips to demystify and help your child ace the college admission interview:

Your Child Controls What Colleges Learn About Them and What They Learn About Colleges

Whereas some schools use this meeting as a formal admission interview (i.e., an evaluative interview), others use it as an informal opportunity to answer students' questions about college life, opportunities to pursue research, study abroad programs, etc. (i.e., an informational interview).

As a former Cornell University admissions interviewer, my experience fits the latter. We were asked to focus on applicants' fit with Cornell and to give them the chance to discuss anything they have not included in their application, like a special talent or interest, a recent accomplishment, or difficult life circumstance.

Tips: Your child should be courteous and sociable to leave a positive impression on their interviewer and learn more about their school. There are many sites that offer guidance on general interview etiquette (e.g., greeting your interviewer with a smile and a firm handshake, sitting upright, etc.), but standout applicants have back-and-forth

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conversations with interviewers, rather than let the interview turn into a question-and-answer session. Some ways your child can achieve this are to:

1. Expand on answers to demonstrate their qualities.

For example, instead of answering, “Creating art is one of my favorite hobbies,” when your child is asked what they enjoy doing during their spare time, they should say something like, “Creating art has been one of my greatest passions for a very long time, and I’m constantly experimenting with new mediums and exploring new styles. For example, although I’ve been creating oil paintings on canvas since I was nine, I started working on metal sculptures two years ago. Adding metal work to my portfolio has been a challenge, but my growth in that area has expanded to my oil paintings, which have improved as a result.”

Whereas the first answer merely tells the interviewer that your child enjoys art, the second answer demonstrates a passion and commitment for art, as well as a motivation to grow. Answering questions the latter way will help your child demonstrate their wonderful qualities, similar to the approach to writing great college essays.

2. Ask the interviewer questions throughout the interview.

Most applicants ask all of their questions toward the end of the interview when the interviewer solicits them.

Waiting until the end automatically creates a question-and-answer session that feels boring and puts pressure on your child to ask great questions that will leave a lasting positive impression.

On the other hand, conversations are more natural—and certainly more memorable—when your child asks questions throughout the interview about the school and its various offerings, as well as about the interviewer and their own college experience.

For example, when your child is asked how they would feel about moving to a rural town for school despite growing up in a big city, they could say, “Moving to a rural locale excites me. I’ve lived in a big city my whole life, where things are often hectic, so I would welcome the opportunity to move to a town with a slower pace and develop a close

community there. I'd love to hear about your experiences moving to rural Pennsylvania for school, since you mentioned growing up in Boston. How was that transition for you?"

This response will demonstrate your child's sociability, genuine interest in the interviewer's experiences, and also their serious consideration in attending that college.

Your child should remember that alumni who volunteer to serve as admission interviewers probably have a lot of pride in their alma mater and think fondly of their college experience. Learning about an interviewer's experiences also provides a glimpse into college life to help your child decide whether they could see themselves happy there.

Your Child Should Prepare for What They Can

The interview setting varies across schools and interviewers.

For example, many interviewers prefer to meet in a quiet room at an alumni club, whereas others like to meet at a busy local coffee shop. The Cornell admissions committee would suggest meeting in more casual locations. Of course, your child may feel more or less comfortable in certain settings.

Tips: Your child should prepare for any situation. Although your child cannot anticipate every question or stressor they will encounter during admissions interviews, there are many aspects that your child *can* plan for ahead of time, including rehearsing answers to common questions. Here are two ways your child can feel more at ease during the actual interview:

3. Reduce anxiety about the interview environment.

If your child is anxious about meeting the interviewer at a public location, they could visit there before the actual interview date. Familiarizing themselves with the setting will help ease your child's nerves and provide realistic expectations about the interview environment.

4. Dress to impress... Sort of.

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Your child should dress as they would for a job interview, regardless of the location. A dress shirt and slacks (ties are optional) for males, and a dress shirt/blouse and slacks/skirt for females would be appropriate. This way, your child will neither be under dressed for a private location or formal interview, nor over dressed for a casual location or informal meeting.

Admissions Interviews Begin Before the Meeting and End After It

First impressions are made before the interview and last impressions after it.

Tips: Your child should treat pre- and post-interview correspondence as part of the interview. Here are three ways your child can make positive impressions before and after the interview:

5. Respond promptly and professionally to the interviewer's initial email.

An enthusiastic and thoughtful response no later than the day after receiving an admission interview offer will exhibit initiative and good social skills.

Conversely, waiting several days to respond may communicate a lack of interest to the interviewer and the school.

Moreover, professionally-written emails that use proper titles (e.g., Mr. for males, Ms. for females) and avoid slang demonstrate maturity.

6. Treat everyone they interact with on interview day with kindness and respect.

Of course your child plans to impress their interviewer with their sociability and enthusiasm. Extending that same courtesy to others at the meeting location (e.g., desk clerks, coffee baristas, etc.) will help your child create a positive impression in their interviewer's mind.

7. Write a thank-you note after the interview.

Sending a follow-up email to thank the interviewer for their time and for answering their questions shows your child's sincerity. It also serves as the final memory with which an interviewer will write their review.

Writing a thank-you note also offers your child an opportunity to mention something specific about the interview that they appreciated. For example, your child could write, "I especially appreciated your advice about not taking too many courses during my freshman year so that I can achieve a good work-life balance."

Final Thoughts

College admissions interviews vary with regard to their intended purpose, formality, and location, and they serve as an important part of the application process.

These interviews allow colleges to assess your child's fit with their culture and offerings. More importantly, your child can use the interview process to reinforce the great qualities they communicated throughout their applications, address any gaps in their applications, and learn about the college experience at a particular school.

Using the tips offered in this lesson to prepare for college admissions interviews will help your child get into the school where they see themselves growing most.

Once they've aced their college interviews, it's time for your child to kick their feet up and wait for those acceptance letters!

Final Thoughts

The college application process is a long and tedious one, but you don't have to navigate it alone. I have helped hundreds of applicants get into their top-choice schools for over fifteen years, and it would be my privilege to help your child do the same.

Therefore, I would love to hear from you. If you have questions about anything covered in this guide or your child's admissions journey, please email me at shirag@shemmassianconsulting.com or schedule a complimentary 30-minute consultation with me by visiting <https://shemmassianconsulting.com/calendar>.

Best of luck!

Sincerely,



Shirag Shemmassian, Ph.D.
Founder | Shemmassian Academic Consulting